The Mystery of the Trinity

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Note on the Text

These chapters began as talks given on retreat in 2025 and 2026. They have been transcribed and lightly edited for reading, but I have kept the voice in which they were spoken.

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Chapter 1 — Icons of the Trinity

I bind unto myself the name, the strong name of the Trinity, by invocation of the same, the three in one, and one in three, of whom all nature hath creation, eternal Father, Spirit, Word. Praise to the Lord of my salvation. Salvation is of Christ the Lord. Amen.

— St. Patrick's Breastplate, trans. Cecil Frances Alexander

St. Patrick and the Shamrock

St. Patrick evangelized Ireland in the fifth century. Years earlier, he had been enslaved there; during his captivity he learned the language and eventually escaped. Later he returned as a missionary to the same land where he had been previously held captive. There, he encountered a pagan culture infected by Druidism, which had its own religious customs and rituals, a reverence for the natural world, and strong beliefs concerning the spiritual powers within it. Having known the language, he was able to preach to the people of Ireland — and many miracles attested to the power of God with him.

When St. Patrick preached, he did not shy away from the central mystery of our faith, and that is the Trinity. Tradition has handed down to us the story of the shamrock. The shamrock was a botanical analogy used to illustrate to a people who may be caught up in the worship of nature how something can be both one and three, that it can share the same life, be connected in the same way, but yet be distinct at the same time. It was a simple analogy, fraught with potential heresy — but just as this is one shamrock with three leaves, so there are three persons in one God. The analogy limps as it does not capture the full reality of the Trinity. We must not take it to mean that God the Father is a part of God, and God the Son is a part of God, and God the Holy Spirit is a part of God. It is however a way to enter into the language of those people and to help them understand, with simplicity, what it means to be one and three. Let us recall how this analogy sufficed for us when we were children — how the shamrock showed we can have three in one. From that, we build on

distinctions and understandings, and theology starts to do the work, notionally, of completing what is going on within the reality of this mystery.

St. Patrick led with the Trinity because it is what our Lord told us to lead with. "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go, therefore, make disciples of all nations, *baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit*" (Matthew 28:18-19). St. Patrick did not shy from holding up a shamrock and saying, "Three in one," to give their imaginations something to grip onto, to give an image that could later be corrected, modified, and through which they could enter into a theological understanding of the mystery at hand. He gave them something to begin the renewal of their minds.

Another Icon of the Trinity

Christian art has generally been hesitant to depict the Trinity. We depict Christ, because "the Word became flesh and dwelt among us" (John 1:14). We can show what He looked like, and there is no affront there to any pious sentiments. To show the Father or the Holy Spirit under a personal form, however, is a challenge, both theologically and artistically.

Traditionally, an icon is said to be "written" rather than painted. The expression distinguishes an icon from ordinary religious artwork; like a sacred text, it bears witness through a language of received images, colors, and gestures.

Andrei Rublev wrote the icon of the Trinity, included on the cover of the book — I recommend consulting it frequently during the next few pages. Rublev circumvents the problem of depicting the Father and the Holy Spirit personally by showing, at face value, the Genesis account where three angelic visitors were sent from God to Abraham and Sarah. Out of an abundance of hospitality, they quickly prepared food for their guests. Abraham was under the Oak of Mamre when the angels communicated to him that Sarah was to conceive in her old age (Genesis 18:1-15).

The scene of these three angels, in retrospect, is a representation of the Trinity. Even here in the Old Testament, where this mystery was still hidden, we see resonances of God's Trinitarian nature. We might say the same of the first chapter of Genesis, when God says, "Let us make man in our image, after our likeness" (Genesis 1:26). We who now know of God as one and three think that the "us," the plural, refers to the Trinity. Of course, we are not wrong. Originally, it acted as a plural of majesty or referred to the heavenly assembly of angels, but for us, we can retroactively understand that in its fullest sense, God creates from the Trinity.

Reading the Icon: One Divinity

Rublev's icon packs a lot of meaning, engaging our imagination in a way that is very helpful, especially for a mystery that often confounds us. I should say up front: iconographers and theologians do not all agree on every detail of this reading — which angel corresponds to which Person, for instance, has been argued over for centuries. What I am giving you is the reading I find most illuminating, but not the only one on record. Here I benefited greatly from the analysis of Fr. James Dominic Brent OP in his book *The Father's House*.

Three angels sit around a table, each clothed in blue — barely visible beneath the garment of the figure on the left, prominent upon the central figure, and clearly displayed by the figure on the right. Blue, in the iconographic tradition, represents divinity. Its presence on all three therefore indicates their one shared divinity.

Likewise they all have the same face and no noticeable differences in their physical appearance. All three of them have a scepter in their left hands, while their right hands are free to bless or command. They all have the same power, same authority, same divinity. Together they form a circle, representing eternity.

The Holy Spirit on the Right

Where we notice differences are in the colors that each one of them wears, starting with the angel on the right. That angel is wearing green over top of the blue, the blue tunic underneath. Green represents the new life. We call new tree growth green wood, or we might think of the greenness of late spring, when the world has once again come to life. Green in the eastern tradition is associated with the Holy Spirit, that breath of life that comes over the world every spring. In the East, they do not wear red for the Holy Spirit, for Pentecost — they wear green. So the angel on the right represents the Holy Spirit, and behind him in the distance is a mountain.

A mountain is associated with the Holy Spirit, especially in the Old Testament where we recall Moses on Mount Sinai or Elijah on Mount Carmel. Mountains symbolize the Holy Spirit and prophecy. In the New Testament, mountains maintain that significance. On Mount Tabor, Christ goes up with Peter, James, and John, and they were all enveloped in the cloud (Luke 9:28-36) — the cloud that symbolized the Holy Spirit — and then the Father's voice was heard. Our thoughts turn also to the mountain, or rather the hill, of Calvary, where Christ gave forth the Spirit. Behind the angel in green, the mountain gathers together associations of revelation, prophecy, and divine presence.

The Son in the Middle

Under his blue garment, the central figure wears a robe whose color lies somewhere between brown, red, and purple. The earthy brown hue recalls the Word's descent into our humanity; its red hue suggests the blood poured out for our salvation; its purple hue evokes his kingship, which is further attested to by the band of gold along his shoulder.

Looking at his right hand: two fingers are extended. This was a typical posture used when raising your hand in blessing in the East. The two fingers represented the humanity and divinity of Christ — what we call the hypostatic union, where God is united with us in our human nature: true God and true man in Christ, fully human and fully divine. The other

three fingers represent the Trinity, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Behind him, there is the tree, the Oak of Mamre. We may also think back to the tree where original sin happened, when Eve plucked that fruit from the tree of knowledge of good and evil. By a tree, humanity fell. We also look forward to the tree of life that is the cross, when Christ goes up on that cross and dies for us. Christ is the new Adam, and he was the one to ascend a tree, to become the fruit of the tree of life on the cross. The tree corroborates the identification of the middle angel as the second person of the Holy Trinity.

The Father on the Left

The angel on the left represents the Father. His outer garment resists simple identification of color. It appears by turns pink, purple, blue, and almost translucent. That elusiveness of color is fitting — the garment seems to withdraw from our attempts to name it, suggesting the mystery of the unseen Father.

Behind him is a house, the house of Abraham and Sarah. Also recall our Lord's words in John 14, "In my Father's house are many rooms" (John 14:2). Or we can go back to Luke 2, "Did you not know that I must be in my Father's house" (Luke 2:49), that is, the temple. In both sayings, the house signifies the dwelling of the Father. The house of Abraham and Sarah here recalls not only their hospitality, but the communion into which Christ welcomes us.

The Postures and the Chalice

Let us examine more closely their postures. The Father's head is up, but the other two are actually looking at the Father. This shows a deference to the Father, recognizing that the Son is begotten of the Father and the Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father, and they both go back to the Father and reverence the Father. Likewise for all of us, we are all from the Father's love and tending to the Father in our own journeys of faith.

Not only are the heads of the Son and the Holy Spirit pointed towards the Father, but even the mountain and the tree are "bowing" towards the Father, so that the Father might be glorified in all things.

The contours of the two outer figures form the outline of a great chalice. In the middle of that visual chalice, we have Christ, whose blood is poured out for us.

The bowl upon the table deepens this Eucharistic meaning. In the bowl is the head of a calf. The bowl with its animal head recalls the covenant meals of the Old Testament and points forward to the New Covenant, in which we are invited to share in the heavenly banquet of the Eucharist. Its shape is actually not quite perfectly symmetrical, and that is likely on purpose. The incompletion of the sacrifices of the Old Testament points to the bread of the new covenant of the Eucharist.

The Rectangle

Notice too the rectangle with a little inner rectangle on the front of this altar. Perhaps the rectangle represents the four corners of the world, that the Trinity is necessarily meant for evangelization, to spread the love of God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, out of the four corners.

Speculatively, there is another meaning of that rectangle. In the altars of the East, there was a compartment in the altar where the relics of martyrs were placed. This is the part of the table that all three persons of the Trinity are not occupying, and we, as the viewer, are now part of this icon. We are invited to this feast, to share in the hospitality of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. How do we do so? The way in which we share in that hospitality is through martyrdom, through the witness of our lives. "Unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit" (John 12:24). Our insertion into the Holy Trinity through Christ is through a sharing in his sufferings and his death on the cross.

With our own prayer, I recommend taking this to the chapel — or your own inner room in your own time of silent recollection — to pray with Rublev's icon.

The Third Icon: The Sign of the Cross

Rublev's icon stands before our eyes, the shamrock before our memory, but the final icon considered here is traced on our bodies: the sign of the cross.

As Catholics, we are very used to beginning and ending prayer with the sign of the cross, as a sort of toggle switch for prayer. Prayer does not "count" only when enclosed within the sign of the cross. Yet the Church's custom of beginning and ending prayer in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit invites us to recover the meaning of words and gestures that familiarity can easily obscure.

In the Name

The sign of the cross consists of words: "In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen." Those words are first uttered over us — with water poured three times over our heads — when we are baptized. The Holy Trinity has a dwelling within us, and those particular words are important. Christ says "in the name," not "in the names." Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are named distinctly, yet they possess one divine name. Even the grammar of the sign of the cross holds together the distinction of the Persons and the unity of God. In our baptisms, these are the words through which we become a "new creation" (2 Corinthians 5:17). When we pray, we invoke those same words — not sloppily, but with great intentionality. *Every* word matters — even the "and of the's!" It is good for us to pray with a reverence as we invoke the central mystery of our faith and our entrance into that mystery through baptism. *In the name.*

Of the Father
Not only are the words important, the actions matter. When we lift our hands towards our foreheads, this upward motion of our hands goes along with "In the name of the Father." That upward motion is this pilgrimage all of us are making to the embrace of God the Father. We who have come forth from the Father are now meant to go towards him in our prayer. This is that simple glance directed towards heaven that St. Thérèse talks about when, in the words the Catechism quotes from her, "prayer is a surge of the heart; it is a simple look turned toward heaven, it is a cry of recognition and of love, embracing both trial and joy" (Catechism of the Catholic Church, no. 2558). *Of the Father.*

And of the Son
The hand then descends, passing over the heart: "and of the Son." The downward movement recalls Christ, the second person of the Holy Trinity, descending, going forth from the Father and entering into our humanity in the incarnation. He not only enters into our humanity, but takes all our sufferings onto himself, all of our misery, all of our sin — the descent of Christ into the depths of human misery. He undergoes this descent out of love for us. He binds us to himself so we might be lifted up to the Father. *And of the Son.*

And of the Holy Spirit

The hand then crosses the body: "and of the Holy Spirit." In the Western tradition, we move from left shoulder to right shoulder. In the East, they go from right shoulder to left shoulder, because, as one tradition explains, the good thief was on the right. In either tradition, the accompanying motion emphasizes that the Holy Spirit is now among us. This is the Holy Spirit that has been sent among us, poured out for the forgiveness of our sins (John 20:22-23). We are living in the age of the Holy Spirit among us, and we cross over our heart, going from shoulder to shoulder. As we cross our hearts, we cross our lungs, for the Holy Spirit is our breath, and we, as members of Christ's body, the Church, are animated by that Spirit. By the mystery of the pouring forth of the Holy Spirit — at the crucifixion, at the Resurrection, in the upper room, and on the feast of Pentecost — that Holy Spirit is among us, animating us. We live and move and have our being in God (Acts 17:28), with, through, and in the Holy Spirit. Therefore, we are to live morally, to live in God's grace, to live the life of the Spirit, as we love God and love one another. *And of the Holy Spirit.*

Amen

The last word of the sign of the cross is no less important. *Amen*. The word comes from a Hebrew root associated with firmness, faithfulness, security, and trust. It is like a peg driven into secure ground, holding fast whatever has been entrusted to it. I imagine the altogether common experience of a dad tightening a ratchet strap, giving a firm tug, and declaring, "That's not going anywhere." In saying *Amen*, we give our assent to something solid enough to bear the weight of our lives. We affirm: this is true; this is firm and trustworthy; let it be so. Our Amen is a whole gift of self, leaving nothing behind. Our prayer begins and ends with the sign of the cross because our whole life is enclosed within this mystery of the Holy Trinity, in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. *Amen.*

Who Are We Crossing? Ourselves

Let us not forget the central image, the central icon of the sign of the cross. Who are we crossing? Ourselves. We are images of God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. We are made in his image and likeness. We have the Trinity in us, inscribed in our very beings, by grace, through baptism. We are temples of the Holy Spirit, sharing an intimacy with Christ in the inner room from which we pray to the Father in secret (Matthew 6:6).

In this image of our very selves, we notice the relationality within the Trinity, the love of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. We are made for relationship. We are made to pour ourselves out and to receive, to give and to receive. We are inscribed with the Trinity in our very natures. When God looked upon unfinished creation all the other days, he saw "it was good" (Genesis 1:4-25). He looked upon us — created in his image and likeness, male and female meant to enshrine that image of the Holy Trinity in our very bodies — and saw that "it was very good" (Genesis 1:31). Our lives are icons of God's triune love.

What that means, how that is lived out, how this changes not just how we approach our faith but everything in our life, we will discuss in the chapters that follow.

Chapter 2 — Mystery

> *O my God, Trinity whom I adore, help me forget myself entirely so to establish myself in you, unmovable and peaceful as if my soul were already in eternity. May nothing be able to trouble my peace or make me leave you, O my unchanging God, but may each minute bring me more deeply into your mystery! Grant my soul peace. Make it your heaven, your beloved dwelling and the place of your rest. May I never abandon you there, but may I be there, whole and entire, completely vigilant in my faith, entirely adoring, and wholly given over to your creative action.*
>
> — Prayer of St. Elizabeth of the Trinity

The Graveyard of Heresies

The Trinity is the most central mystery in our faith, and it matters very much. It also matters what we mean by the word mystery. We think of the Trinity as something that we cannot possibly understand, and it confounds us.

I am sure that many of you have heard homilies on Trinity Sunday — the one Sunday a year when priests feel compelled to at least mention the Trinity, the central mystery of our faith — homilies that say we cannot possibly speak too much about the Trinity, because if we do, we might fall into heresy. If you talk for longer than 10 minutes, you will likely say something wrong, and there are many Trinitarian heresies.

We look over the history of Christianity, especially in the early years, and — as Pope Benedict says, that is, as Joseph Ratzinger in *Introduction to Christianity* — we see "a graveyard of heresies." We want out of that graveyard.

We do not even have our minds wrapped around what the problems were for the early Christians — except for a few things here and there, like "Arianism is wrong." We do not want to go anywhere near Arianism, so we conclude, "The Trinity is a mystery, we cannot understand it," and we stop there, even though we read in the Catechism that the Trinity is the central Christian mystery.

I once heard a speaker at a FOCUS conference tell about a conversation he had when he was a Protestant. His Catholic friend persuaded him to meet up with a Jesuit priest — supposedly a good Jesuit — and the priest asked him, "What is the central mystery of our faith?" The man, since he was a Protestant, answered, trying to be a little bit edgy: "Justification by faith alone." And the priest said, "It is the Trinity." The man said, "Oh yeah — that is right." Then the realization dawned: it is the love that made the sun and the stars — the love shared between Father, Son, and the Holy Spirit that spills out into all creation. And then, even though we fell, by God's mercy extended to us through the Trinity — God the Father of mercies; the death and resurrection of his Son; the Holy Spirit sent among us for the forgiveness of sins

— the whole action of the Trinity comes to redeem us and bring us back to himself. The Trinity is the central faith. It is the Trinity that we will gaze on — and partake of — through Christ, in the beatific vision, where God gives us his very self through which to understand him.

Every single time, we just dismiss it: "Okay, the Trinity is something I cannot understand. I am not even going to try. It is three and one — three persons, one God. They are all one God; somehow they are connected very deeply, but they are distinct. How they are distinct, I do not know how that works. But I know Jesus was the second person of the Holy Trinity, and the Holy Spirit is the third person, and there is God the Father. But was God the Father sort of the God of the Old Testament? Was Jesus the God of the New Testament?" And no — that is wrong. That is modalism. Do not think that way. We start messing up with this, and we say, "Okay, that is enough. I am done. I do not want to think about it. I cannot understand it." In fact, the Trinity is just something that you study when you are on the way to being a priest. That is it. You know, in seminary you can study it. You can read St. Augustine. Maybe you read St. Elizabeth of the Trinity, and you think, "Okay, she really digs the Trinity. That is cool. That is great — for her. But for me, I am just going to simplify it and not think about it too much."

The Trinity is a mystery. We cannot understand it. It is there. It is a huge part of our faith, but we just cannot come close to it at all. We do not even try — although we invoke the Trinity at every sign of the cross, at every Glory Be, and every time at Mass in the doxology. It is all three of them together; it happens all the time, but we do not let it have any meaning for us. We are inoculated from the mystery of the Trinity. It is something we hear, something we practice, but not something that we really grasp at all.

Mystery Novels and Jigsaw Puzzles

When we hear the word mystery, one thing that comes to mind is mystery novels — Arthur Conan Doyle's Sherlock Holmes, Father Brown. Those are mystery stories. Mysteries, in that case, are something that need to be solved. There is something we do not know. Who committed the murder? How did it happen? What were the motivations? Who needs to be arrested? The mystery is solved in a mystery novel.

There are pieces of information that are not there, or if they are present, they require us to deduce from the material given to arrive at the conclusion. Usually a mystery in this sense is something we do not know and need to find out, or something we just need to piece together. It is solved. Like a jigsaw puzzle, we put it together and we see the picture, and there you go. Or it is like a problem in physics: you come up with the answer through calculating, putting in the different measurements, and you arrive at your answer. Or a problem in engineering: you need to optimize something, using the things that we have on hand — the materials and the designs — and within the design limitations, you optimize. Optimization, too, is a problem — and we reduce much of what we do in our life to problems that need to be solved.

What We Mean by Christian Mystery

Seeing mystery as a problem to be solved is not what we mean by Christian mystery. When we think about the mystery of faith — the central mystery of our faith being the Trinity — we also might think of the Holy Eucharist. We might know that in the Eastern Catholic tradition the sacraments are called mysteries, and the Blessed Sacrament is called the mysteries, very simply.

When we say that, we do not mean, oh, a problem to be solved, that we cannot know it. It is not possible to know it. We mean something that is so knowable that it overwhelms our ability to know.

The Sun

If you were to go outside on a sunny day and try to gaze at the sun — are you able to see the sun? In one sense, yes, because it is so much light; in another sense, no. You cannot really see the sun. You cannot see its outline. All you see is blinding light.

So you would not say the sun is invisible. You would say the sun is so visible that it overwhelms your ability to see. Your retina cannot handle that sun, but at the same time, the sun is useful in analogy, because the sun is that by which we see everything else.

A mystery is likewise: as Jacques Maritain said — he was a philosopher, a Thomist philosopher in the 20th century — mysteries are "pregnant with intelligibility." They are so full of things we can know that it is too much. We are a finite intellect in the midst of something infinite, and it is overwhelming.

So what do we do? We can try to get away from it, treat it like a problem, go nowhere near it — or enter into it.

Mysteries Implicate the Self

Another philosopher in the 20th century — his name was Gabriel Marcel — belonged to a school of philosophy called personalism, a school you might recognize as the one Karol Wojtyła was also involved in, on the other side of Europe.

He said that a mystery is "a problem which encroaches upon its own data, invading them, as it were, and thereby transcending itself as a simple problem." Mysteries *implicate* the self. You are involved in the mystery. When we approach something as a problem, we approach it as separate from ourselves. It is outside of us. It can be measured. It can be analyzed. If it remains unchanged, we remain unchanged, and it can be solved.

Gabriel Marcel said that many of the problems of the 20th century — with their massive amounts of death on scales

never before envisioned — came from treating mysteries as problems.

Persons Are Not Problems

St. John Henry Newman said that each of us is "an infinite abyss of existence." That is to say, each of us is a mystery, so knowable that it overwhelms anyone's ability to know. We are even a mystery unto ourselves. When we fully know ourselves, that knowledge overwhelms us. Self-knowledge and knowledge of God are brought together, and we might call that union the virtue of humility — when we know ourselves, we know God, and when we see the discrepancy between the two, we act accordingly. To treat another person as a problem, to use them as part of an equation, is to dismiss them at their very core.

This dismissal of persons was the "solution" to the "Jewish problem" in 1930s and 40s Germany: to treat a whole section of society, a whole accumulation of mysteries of persons, as problems — problems to be solved. When you are dealing with persons, the solution is death. It was an extension of living in a technical world — optimizing everything, having control over everything. Persons are not problems. They themselves are mysteries — not to be rejected, not to be cast out, not to be solved, but to be loved, to be known.

The Two Aspects of Mystery

We might think that was a terrible time in our history. We have certainly learned from that time — and hopefully we have, but we have moved now in the 21st century into the matters of the technical, the problematical. Everything is reduced to a problem. Everything can be solved now by artificial intelligence.

There are many that would even espouse as their way of viewing the world — their central worldview — that science is their God, because everything can be analyzed and measured, and they can be kept safe from everything. That worldview is fundamentally an attitude of fear that causes us to reduce the mysteries, the persons around us, into problems, and to deal with them on the merely technical

level. One of the reasons why we become so anxious all the time is that we are in a world that only lives as problems.

But to approach something as a mystery, we recognize that it is so knowable that it overwhelms us, and we are enveloped in it. The two aspects are these: first, mystery is so knowable that it overwhelms us, and second, it necessarily involves us. We are implicated in it.

We use the word "implicated" to talk about being implicated in a crime. I buy a bike from a friend at a really good deal and recognize that the friend stole the bike from someone else. I am implicated in that crime.

But are we then cut off entirely, irreparably? When we are about to surrender our weakness to God, we say, "Lord, I messed this up. Can you do something about it?" And then we let it go. Then, if we reflect on that particular thing that we did — which we are foolish and shameful about — maybe a couple of years later, we look back and say, "Oh, wow — the Lord took care of that relationship, or the Lord took care of that situation." I did not need to say that the world has ended just because of that. God's mercy transforms, and even in that moment, we can see God loving us — that he is not far from us, even when we want to be far from him. Sin might be such an attempt: "I am going to take matters into my own hands and do the thing that I know I ought not to do" — but even there, we are caught up in the mystery of God's mercy. It still requires us to choose to receive that mercy, but we go back and we can see that God's goodness is there, and his fidelity is unchanging, even though ours is not.

Elisabeth and the Moon

I will tell a story to illustrate this point about mystery involving the self. Several years ago, my sister's family was returning from a visit to my brother-in-law's family in eastern Pennsylvania. Afterwards I talked to my niece Elisabeth, who was five years old at the time. I just asked her, "Elisabeth, how was your trip?" She said to me, "Uncle PJ" — because she calls me Uncle PJ — "Did you know that, when I go places, the moon follows me? It really does!"

And my heart sank. I felt bad for her; in my mind, I am thinking, this belief is like one of those Santa Claus moments. Elisabeth, you are five years old. You need to know something about reality. The moon does not follow you. It is so far away that at 60 or 70 miles per hour you will not be able to notice any change in its position in the sky relative to you. It only looks like it is following you because of the great distance it is away from you — it is so unbelievably large that it seems to only be stuck in the sky. As you travel, it looks like it is also going with you. That is not the case.

And I am thinking, how can I prove it to her? The whole exchange is happening in a very short period of time, because I have to prove to her that it is not true. Maybe I could apply the principle of non-contradiction, or some variant of it. Why do we not take you, Elisabeth, in one car at night, and your sister, Mary Margaret, and put her in another car? And why do you not drive in separate directions, and both of you observe the moon. It cannot be following both of you. That cannot be true. You must look for another explanation.

Quickly, I said to Elisabeth, "Elisabeth, that is not true. The moon does not follow you. It is so far away. It only looks like it is following you." And before I could explain my idea for an experiment that would disprove her childish notion, she interrupted me: "No, the moon really follows me." And with such opposition, I abandoned my attempt to scientifically disprove her childish perception.

Elisabeth was right, in a sense. She approached the moon as a mystery. Its own movements were not separate from hers. She was involved in it.

For me, the moon was a problem. It could be analyzed. We could measure it. I could explain the different things about it. I could talk about why it looks like it has different shapes — those shapes are due to the phases. I could talk about why we only see one side of it, even though it is a sphere — because it is tidally locked to the Earth. I would love to be able to explain all these things — to talk about how those shapes you see on its surface are actually impact craters from asteroids

and meteors and other space debris, and that they themselves were shaped by impacts from asteroids, meteors, and other space debris.

Squashing Wonder

But she saw the moon as if it had a personality, as if it had a care for her. In my own fear — not wanting to think something cared for me, only to find out that it does not — I thought it was necessary to dissuade her from that childish notion, and in so doing, I squashed her wonder — or at least I tried to. She would not let me. The moon was a mystery to her. She was involved in it.

When we think about God, God is a mystery. He overwhelms us. There is so much to know. We cannot possibly contain God. You cannot hug a mountain. Or if you try to, you will just look silly, because your arms do not go around it. It is beyond you; no matter what you attempt, it slips through your fingers like sand on the seashore.

Augustine's Boy

We remember the old legend of St. Augustine, walking along a beach and finding a boy, digging a hole, taking a pail and going to the ocean and dumping ocean water into that hole on the seashore. "What are you doing, boy?" "I am pouring the ocean into this hole." "Well, you cannot do that. The ocean will not fit. All the water you pour in will just seep into the sand and return to the ocean." And the same is true, the boy says, when you try to understand God as one and three.

How Far Analysis Goes

The Trinity overwhelms us. We can analyze it to an extent. We can divide it up. We can theologically distinguish its properties and inherent notions. We can say that there is the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Each one of them is a subsistent relation. We can say that each one of them has their own role in coming down into this world. In some way or other, they go forth — the missions of the Trinity — to draw us into the Trinity.

We can talk about the Trinity in history. We can talk about the Trinity in theology. We can apply the dictums of philosophy to the Trinity — but the mind's progress in wisdom, Maritain said, is made "by an adhesion of the mind to its object and a union with it increasingly profound, progress as it were by a growing intimacy" — and "a philosophy unaware of mystery would not be a philosophy." We can expand our mind and try to grasp as much as we can, but we still find ourselves unable to. The most proper response to the Trinity is to understand that we are involved in it already, that we are implicated in that very mystery.

It is not wrong to study the Trinity — in fact, there are many things to study about it, and that is why we actually have teachings about it: dogma, which is official Church teaching. Flannery O'Connor said: "Dogma is the guardian of mystery. The doctrines are spiritually significant in ways that we cannot fathom." So it is not wrong to study dogmas, and it is not wrong to treat the Trinity as a problem to be solved — but we have to also recognize that it must be a mystery that we adore.

Even knowing something means that we are participating in God, for there is not anything that is separate from God. He comes to save us. He comes to save you — not just us in general, but you. You.

A Way of Approaching All Reality

Mystery is not just a category that we can put things in. It is a way of approaching reality. I can say this table is a mystery. I am involved in it. I have a history with it. I have a story to tell. I have a way in which I am connected to it. It is not just a horizontal plane elevated with finite width and length. Now this table is something that separates me from you, but it also is something that allows me to be here with you. We recognize that we have a part to play in it.

This lamp here even is a mystery. I cannot see the light, but by that light, I see other things. Logically, I do not think an engineered product is a mystery, but this lamp has memories for me. It has been here since my first retreat. I replaced the

light bulb in it myself during a hard time, and this place was for me a place of solace, and every light bulb — the ceilings and the lamps — now reminds me of God providing for me during a very difficult time. Now there is a story attached to it. Even there, an engineered product can be engaged as a story, as a mystery.

We could also consider it separately, as if I am not involved in it. I could also engage with it as mystery, as something that is brimming with the invisible.

Just as with this table, every person is potentially a mystery. Every person is potentially a mystery to me in some way — which is another way of saying that every person is potentially someone to be loved.

The engagement with our world, all creation, as mystery, is preparation for engaging God as mystery.

In the ancient world, engaging the cosmos as mystery was not so uncommon: even grown men would look up at the sky at night, see the stars, draw pictures in the sky, and connect them to their maps of meaning. They would see their maps of meaning reflected in the cosmos through the myths that they would tell, the stories that they would share with their children and with others in society. Cosmos — they engage with the sky, with the stars, as mystery, as if it involved them.

For them, as for Elisabeth, the moon really did follow. The stars really do care for us — in the sense that we are all made for relationship, and we all live in relation to everything else.

When I observe the stars at night, I do not look up there and see constellations — I might be able to identify a few. When I think of the stars, I know what they are. I know they are balls of plasma, many light-years away — but actually, to me, that knowledge moves me more towards wonder. When I know more about what it is, it is even more interesting and amazing. I think astronomy might be one of the areas where you find fewer atheists among scientists, because you can go from the massive scale of everything — the beauty, the order of

creation. It was all hidden from our eyes for so long. It reveals the vastness, the sheer excess of creation, and it moves me towards wonder. We can go from the problem — the measurable, the fact that we can actually travel to the moon and land on it — and also to wonder. It was amazing for those astronauts there. The first time they went around the moon — before they even landed on it — they saw an earthrise as they were orbiting the moon. They were the first human beings ever to see an earthrise. These astronauts looking back on the Earth and seeing it all as one planet moved them towards the idea of a greater unity. The earthrise was a wonder — and a wonder that was transmitted back to the world; years later, the Apollo 17 astronauts took the "blue marble" photograph, the whole Earth in a single frame. It was a movement towards a wonder.

The Proper Response

When we talk about the Trinity as mystery going forward on this retreat, we need to hold in our minds what we mean by mystery. We do not mean to ever excuse it and say we cannot access it, because that excuse is actually the exact wrong approach to mystery. To approach mystery is to access it, to enter in, to be enveloped by it, to see that we ourselves are included and caught up in a relationship.

This is what the Trinity is. It is not so far away, so transcendent, so separated from us that we have nothing to do with it — that we can analyze it from afar, treat it with theology, apply the history of Christianity to it, and say, "Well, that is Sabellianism, that is modalism, that is pseudo-Pelagianism" — that last label is probably not applied to the Trinity, but that is okay. Or we can understand that we are already living in it — that the Trinity involves us: we have our origin in the love of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, spilling over into creation; each of us is a thought of God, willed by him and made for him. We want to say, "No. Well, somehow we are separate. Somehow everything is determined. Somehow everything is just coming forth from matter, from different material causes — maybe even randomly — in order to produce us, where we are right now." No. None of us is

meaningless. None of us is random. Each one of us is willed. Because all of us come forth from the Trinity, we are made for the triune love. We are made to be inserted, through Christ, in the love of God: Father, Son, Holy Spirit. We are implicated in the Holy Trinity.

How do we practice this? Maybe just a recognizing — just seeing that there is mystery here, that in some way the love of God is spilling out here. We hear the voice of the Father: "This is my beloved Son" — and it applies to us too, by adoption, as other Christs, as Christians, as it does to the second person of the Holy Trinity. We are given that same Spirit through which we cry out, "Abba, Father." We are joined at the level of our beings to this love. We cannot dismiss this mystery: it is absolutely central to our faith, absolutely central to our prayer, central to our very selves.

That Trinity that made the sun and the stars — the love Dante called, at the end of the *Paradiso*, "the love that moves the sun and the other stars" — the moon in the sky that follows us as we traverse long distances — that Trinity is within us. For God has come to dwell in our hearts, and he is within. We have been baptized into Christ, and we have been given this Holy Trinity as an indwelling within us — to be a home of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — even as we ache to be in that home of the Father's house in heaven.

And the proper Christian response to mystery is to love, adore, and worship.

God is so beyond our finite grasp that He encompasses us in His infinite embrace.

Chapter 3 — Gift and Liturgy

As a deer longs for flowing streams, so longs my soul for you, O God. My soul thirsts for God, for the living God. When shall I come and behold the face of God? My tears have been my food day and night, while men say to me continually, "Where is your God." These things I remember, as I pour out my soul: how I went with the throng, and led them in procession to the house of God, with glad shouts and songs of thanksgiving, a multitude keeping festival. Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you disquieted within me? Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my savior and my God. My soul is cast down within me, therefore I remember you from the land of Jordan and of Hermon, from Mount Mizar. Deep calls to deep at the thunder of your cataracts; all your waves and your billows have gone over me. Amen.

— Psalm 42:1–7

Thirst opens this chapter, and thirst will carry it to its end: deep calling to deep.

St. Paul, in the twelfth chapter of his letter to the Romans, says, "Do not be conformed to this world but be transformed by the renewal of your mind." I propose that at least one way — and I will not say the only way — to be transformed by the renewal of your mind is to see mystery, to encounter realities as mysteries, to see the meaning behind that which presents itself to the senses, that which can be measured, to go from beyond the merely problematical to the actual mystery at hand — and not to be deterred by the enormity of the mysteries, but instead to enter in, to recognize that we are implicated in them. To be implicated in them is a good thing, because we ourselves are good. This way of seeing is part of what we call sacramentality.

The Trinity of love that overflows

Understanding God as mystery — that he is one God, one divine nature, and three divine persons — we see that everything that God does is mysterious. There is a way in which we are implicated in it. We can think of creation itself as mysterious, approaching it as a mystery, for we ourselves are created. The uncreated love created love out of his creativity, as one of the retreatants put it. Joseph Ratzinger speaks of creation in the same way. God's love spilled out. He was infinitely perfect within himself. There was no need, in one sense, to create. For God was love within three persons — a communion of love, not some lonely figure off in another world unto himself, but fully loving. God pouring himself out, Father to Son, Son to Father, that love being the Holy Spirit. This Trinity is a Trinity of love. That love made us.

There is an artist of the twentieth century named M.C. Escher, and he drew two mind-bending staircases and a waterfall, with water that seems to be flowing back and forth, going up and falling back down, defying the laws of physics. The idea is of water constantly flowing, going up — though we do not know how — and then falling right back down.

When I was in college, I remember how Fr. Michael explained the Trinity — he would try to draw a picture of it — as three buckets. One bucket would pour out into the other bucket. I made a picture. This picture is my attempt, not at the M.C. Escher waterfall, but at the P.J. Gruber Trinitarian waterfall. It is imperfect, but the idea is simple: three pools, the water pouring from one down into the next and back around again. There is a constant pouring.

Creation is a going forth of the love of God — God making something that is not God, not so that we might be separated from God, but so that we might return to him. In Latin, there is a phrase — two words: *exitus, reditus*. *Exitus* sounds like exit — for Latin often works that way — and then *reditus*. There is a going out, an exiting, and a return. God creates that which is not God in order that everything he creates might return to him in the way that is fitting for that creation.

Made to respond

God made creation so that creation could respond. He threw across the sky distant galaxies, stars, and nebulae, and he created one planet within one solar system that was able to sustain life. In that one planet, in that one particular place, he created male and female after his own image and likeness. God is relational in himself, and when he created us male and female, he made us relationally, made for relationship — which is to give of ourselves, not just in a way of interacting with the environment and with each other in bits and pieces, but to give of ourselves in our totality. He made us personal.

The three divine persons are, within the Trinity, subsistent relations. We are also, in a similar way but different, individual substances of a rational, relational nature — in a way different from God, but also in a way imaging him. We show forth the Trinity. Every time we make the sign of the cross over ourselves, we recognize that we ourselves are in the image and likeness of God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. In that way, we are made to respond.

Creation is the gift of God — a going out of the Trinity — and all creation responds through us. The response of all creation through humanity, and in particular through Christ, who is true God and true man: we call "liturgy." Typically, when we hear liturgy, we think perhaps of the rubrics, the rules, about how we are to celebrate Mass and pray the liturgy of the hours. Liturgy, more broadly speaking, is our response to God.

"Mine"

He wanted Adam and Eve to respond, for they were made capable of responding, in God's image and likeness. Adam and Eve turned in on themselves. They grasped after what was going to be given to them as a gift in due time. They made it their possession. Eve reached out, grasped that fruit. She said, "*Mine*." When she said "Mine," she cut herself off from communion with God and with Adam. Subsequently Adam shared in that fall. Thus cut off, humanity waited to be united. All the liturgies of the Old Testament — all the rituals and sacrifices, all the prayers and the psalms — everything pointed to a time when humanity could make that full response. It was not until grace entered into creation again, preveniently in the soul of the Blessed Virgin Mary at the moment of her conception, that God could find within humanity a complete response.

Mary's yes

God created. He speaks in the form of "let there be": "Let us make," he says; "let there be light." *Fiat lux* — and there was light. "Let the dry land appear." And there it was, dry land. God creates waiting for an echo of response. It was not until the Blessed Virgin Mary, as a young woman, responded to God's will: "Let it be to me according to your word." God said — Mary said — and the Word became flesh and dwelt among us. God, who said, "Let there be light," finally received a full response from a creature. *Fiat lux — fiat mihi secundum verbum tuum.* Mary's response — that is the liturgical response.

And when Jesus teaches us how to pray, he says, "When you pray, pray this way: Our Father, who art in heaven, hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come, thy will be done — *fiat voluntas tua* — thy will be done on earth as it is in heaven." When we pray the "Our Father," recognizing we pray it with confidence, within and through Christ, who is our insertion into the Holy Trinity, we are echoing God's creation. We are giving that full response in our totality back to God.

We have access to God the Father because Christ has given us that access through his Sacred Heart. Before that, in the rites of the ancient Jews, there was a veil that no one could enter beyond, a veil that stopped anyone from seeing into the Holy of Holies. Only the high priest could go once a year, and he would say the name of God there. We have access, because we have Christ, and his Heart was that veil that was pierced for us.

As one author, Aidan Kavanagh, said: "The liturgy is doing the world the way the world was meant to be done." We have all these things that are not God, but they show something of God. They are teeming with his life, with his existence, and the whole world aches to give this response. Liturgy is this response. Liturgy is, in effect, a response to a question that we ourselves could have. I might say, why this chair? For sitting. Why food? For eating. Why something rather than nothing? Liturgy.

When we come together and we pray in union with Christ, as members of his mystical body, his bride, the Church, we are making that response. Our response is not lessened because we are part of a whole. We ourselves are wholes within it: we make this full response, for we are as the Church, collectively and individually. We are a spouse to Christ, and we make this prayer to God our Father. We are given the Holy Spirit, who teaches us how to pray, "Abba, Father." Liturgy is how we live now as Catholics.

All liturgy is received. Think about what distinguishes liturgy from even our private prayers. When I pray, just talking to God as a friend, which is a very good thing to do, that private prayer is not liturgical. A liturgy is something we receive. There are guidelines, there are words we use, there are instructions that we follow. They are a gift. Liturgy is itself a gift.

Liturgy engages all the different parts of us — the physicality of our human bodies, being present physically. Liturgy is bodily. It means being physically present, and it means, as best as possible, being mentally present. I do not think people

need to accuse themselves more than they already do about being distracted at Mass, because your mind will not be able to be focused the entire time. It is not about being focused. It is about being present — and being present and being focused are different things. Our minds do wander. It just does not matter, in some ways. I am present. I am not necessarily focused. Because sometimes focus is to treat it as a problem, not as the mystery itself. To be present, to respond — the Church emphasizes active participation, which is a way to say actual participation, like your heart is being joined to what is going on. Being intentional — that is all part of our response.

Receiving Holy Communion, in some ways, is not even the big point of going to Mass. The point of going to Mass is the praise and glory of God the Father — which means that if you ate a sandwich right before Mass, it is still good for you to be at Mass, even if you do not receive.

The liturgies of the Church — the rites of the Church that regard the sacraments — sometimes these rites are done within the Mass but are distinct rites; they are liturgical acts. I do not make up the words of the Eucharistic Prayer, for example. To make them up would be wrong. The Church says, no, you have to use these words. You have options, but you can only use these words. Other prayers, however, could be influenced by Scripture, which is also received — and Scripture is meant to be proclaimed liturgically. The Liturgy of the Word is actually a prayer to God the Father first and foremost.

Baptism: inserted into the Trinity

Understanding this liturgy, we have within it the seven sacraments, the first of which is baptism. Baptism is the sacrament — the mystery itself — by which we are incorporated into Christ, in which we are made beloved sons through Christ, the eternal Son of the Father. Through him who received fully our human nature, we receive adoption as sons. We are then truly sons, more by grace than we are sons of our biological fathers by nature. We are inserted into the Trinity. God's life is poured over us. When that water hits our head three times, in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, what is enacted through material means is done immaterially, and grace is given.

We are washed clean, original sin being wiped away. We are restored, and we are elevated. Made in the image and likeness of God, but that image, marred by original sin, is now made perfect, and ready for that perfection which Christ invites us to. Baptism is our entrance into divine life. We use the word "grace" — in this case, sanctifying grace — to mean the life of the Blessed Trinity within us. Baptism opens us up to the other sacraments as well: confirmation — we are sealed with the gift of the Holy Spirit — and the Holy Eucharist — we are fed with the bread of eternal life. We have the sacraments of vocation — of marriage, of priesthood — and the sacraments of healing — of confession, and anointing of the sick. In all of these sacraments, there is involved a pouring out of God, usually through material means of some kind.

The devotion of our lives — you could say that the living of a daily prayer life is an extension of our baptism, which is itself liturgy, where we are immersed and poured over with water.

Everything is positive

The sacramental life is how we live as Catholics. We also have the broader idea of sacramentality: not just the seven sacraments, but recognizing that all visible things point to the invisible, all material creation comes with the immaterial — it is a package of something beyond us. There is a mystery to behold — and every leaf that falls from a tree, every blade of grass, every hair on our heads — there is mystery, and there is gift.

Luigi Giussani, one of the great religious thinkers of the 20th century would say “everything is positive.” Everything is good, and if it does not exist, it is not good. Sin is nothingness. Christ said, "Apart from me you can do nothing." And when we sin, we do nothing, though everything — everything that shares in God — shares in his goodness. Even sin reaches after something good. Sin is our attempt to grasp after something that is good — but not good for us right now — and instead to insert some nothingness into it. As one twentieth-century author put it — Bruce Marshall — "the young man who rings the bell at the brothel is unconsciously looking for God." There is always goodness, and there is no reason to ever be discouraged. There is no reason to ever despair. Everything of our own lives, everything we encounter, is teeming with that life, is teeming with that mystery, is teeming with that gift underneath it.

St. Thérèse said at the end of her life, before she was about to expire from tuberculosis — a very painful, terrible disease — that everything is grace. God's life is in everything. It is brimming with mystery. For this reason, St. Augustine could see the Trinity in everything, or St. Elizabeth of the Trinity could not help but talk about the Trinity in everything she would see — for the relations between objects and persons, between person and person, everything communicated something of the Trinity. Everything is gift. St. Elizabeth of the Trinity: how can you not contemplate the Trinity? How can you not see it between the fruitfulness of a friendship or the delight of someone seeing you and asking, "Hey, how have you been doing since that thing happened?" Honestly,

there is a Trinity right there, spilling over into my life. That is mysterious, in the true Christian mystery sense.

Is a number a mystery? It seems like if we say yes, we are simply applying mystery to anything — and we can recognize that everything could be engaged as mystery, and everything could be engaged as a problem.

This engagement with everything as mystery is a fundamentally different way to view all reality. How we see the world is utterly different. We work with totalities. We work with wholes. We work with the mystery coming through, shining through the veil of the material world.

The enchanted world and the law of the gift

We are living in an enchanted world. Not that it is magic in the sense of the occult, but it is magical and enchanted, because the material world is brimming with the invisible. We need to have the sacramental vision by which we see all things. When we are transformed by the renewal of our mind steeped in the sacramental vision, we will want to respond.

We are surrounded by nature, and I hope you will go outside this afternoon and see that behind every rock there is a life — a whole sort of microcosm of existence. It is a fun time of the year to overturn rocks and find the salamanders that are hiding underneath. I encourage you to do that, because there is so much more going on behind the surface, and the beauty is that the invisible comes through the visible. This vision is called, more broadly, sacramentality.

Recall St. John Paul II's Theology of the Body. He speaks often of the law of the gift, as it is commonly called. In this world, when we give something away, a material thing, I no longer have it. I hand it over, and it is no longer mine. Gift is a mystery. You know your intentions behind a gift, but you do not understand how the receiver is also receiving. These two things are joined together. It is too much to go into now, but it is already including us. In the world of grace, when I give, I do not lose. In fact, I gain. Giving over something, we gain.

Our response to all of God's creation, all of God's gifts, every one of God's blessings, is that of thanksgiving and praise.

I have come to think more and more that one of the solutions to a lot of the problems we have in this world is thanksgiving — to recognize the blessings God has poured out for us and to give that response — even that liturgical response, the Thanksgiving, the Eucharist, of our holy sacrifice of the Mass. Thanksgiving is a solution because it recognizes everything as the gift that it actually is.

And if everything is good, then everything is gift. To live in gift — this is a distillation of what it means to live in the Spirit. The gift of God Most High poured out for us — the love of Father and Son proceeding forth from them both, coming down to us, living among us, living within us. To live in the Spirit is to live in that gift and to make a gift of ourselves back to God.

Two kinds of feedback

And there is something that happens when we give ourselves back, because of the law of the gift. There is something that St. John Paul II understood, something that St. John of the Cross certainly understood, and St. Louis de Montfort understood, in his devotion to Mary. We give totalities. We do not give just pieces — it is a total consecration of ourselves. We give again. Now we have more to give, and then we gain more. In the world of engineering and signal processing, this cycle is called a positive feedback loop.

There are two kinds of feedback loops. One is called a negative feedback loop. This is the safe kind. In your car, cruise control is a negative feedback loop. If you start going faster than your speed, the car will slow down. If you start going slower, the car speeds up. If there is a negative change in speed, the car reverses it, to return to that speed of 70 miles per hour. A negative feedback loop establishes equilibrium and balance.

Much of our lives, we think about having balance and equilibrium, and there is a usefulness to it. A positive

feedback loop does not reverse the change when it is fed back into the system. We might think of a positive feedback loop in a car. If the car started going faster down a hill, and if it was a positive feedback loop, it would actually rev the engine more to make the car go faster. Because the car is going even faster, the feedback would make the car go even faster than that, and eventually the car is going 180 miles per hour and it cannot be controlled. That is dangerous.

In chemical explosions, you need heat in order for there to be a chemical reaction. There is a small chemical reaction, and it makes more heat, which causes more chemical reactions, and eventually this cycle results in an explosion. Chain reactions in a nuclear bomb result in a massive explosion. That chain reaction is a positive feedback loop. A positive feedback loop is disastrous, you think, in so many different contexts. When you have, for example, speakers and a microphone — many of us have had the experience of someone with a microphone walking in front of a speaker — the speaker projects the sound, and it is picked up by the microphone. The microphone takes that sound and puts it in the speaker and amplifies it, and you hear this loud screech. The screech is a positive feedback loop. It is totally undesirable in so many different contexts. In engineering, a positive feedback loop is destructive; the opposite is true in our relationship with God.

The positive feedback loop of grace

God gives of himself totally to us in creation and in redemption, and we respond totally with the gift of ourselves in baptism, in the life of the baptized, in the sacraments, in our devotions, our prayers — we give ourselves back to God, and his mysteries, the mysteries of the rosary, and we gain, and God gives, and we give back, and we gain, and we gain — and the gain is exponential. That cycle is the positive feedback loop of grace, our liturgical life lived to its completion.

In the prayer of the liturgy, we make the response of the whole Church together, in unity with Christ, to the Father. We pray the prayer of the Mass. Who is the Mass directed to? The Father. That is right. Who is the prayer directed to? Oh,

Jesus. Everything is about Jesus. No. It is the prayer of Jesus to the Father, that we are being included in, that we are being offered now to God the Father. We make that response in the unity of the Holy Spirit — through him, with him, and in him. O God, almighty Father, in the unity of the Holy Spirit, all glory and honor is yours, forever and ever. We are joining in with the Son's gift back to God the Father. His thanksgiving — his Eucharist — for coming forth from God the Father from eternity, he gives himself back. Eucharistic self-gift reflects and reveals Trinitarian love, and we participate in that same prayer. What Christ did on the cross, when he went and died and gave himself so totally to the Father, he has done from the heart of the blessed Trinity for all eternity, and we participate in that. In the Mass, this prayer is the highest gift. It is the source and summit of our faith.

Deep calls to deep

We are made for this infinity. We who are infinite abysses of existence cry out, and we pour ourselves out. In Greek, the word is kenosis — to pour out. St. Thérèse says, love is to be poured out into another. Going back to the words of Psalm 42, deep calls unto deep. From the abyss of our hearts, we call out to the abyss of the Holy Trinity — an abyss calling upon an abyss, a communication going between two, between an I and a thou. All your torrents and all your waves washed over me. This washing-over is utterly catastrophic in this world. To be under a waterfall would result in a lot of death. To be caught up in the waters of chaos and death — typically a deadly activity — is something an ancient Jew would have had a fear of. The ancient Israelites feared the deep. The fear of water was present from the beginning — the chaos that order needed to be instilled upon, the water. In our prayer, deep calls unto deep. This deep calling happens within the heart of the Trinity, and it happens with us. We find our meaning in receiving from the love of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, and we call upon him, and he calls upon us. In the life of the Trinity, we are meant to be washed over, continually swept up — God's pouring out of himself and his triune grace. To that call we respond, let it happen. Let deep call out unto deep. Let me make this prayer of hope.

To hope is to affirm being, says Gabriel Marcel. To despair is to negate being, to give up on all existence. To hope in God is what we are being called into, in the life of the Trinity that we live. We who are other Christs, we who are Christians, are inserted into that holy mystery of the sacred Trinity. We make that full response of ourselves. It is unceasing. It enters into the way we live our lives, even in our work — to use the world well, so we might make that response of the world to God.

All of this is pointing us towards that heavenly liturgy — the rivers of water that we would be partaking of, the waters of love that wash over us, the torrents and the waves that overwhelm us. This washing-over is what is happening in the holy liturgy. We are part of something so much greater — not just the mere sacramentality of the visible and the invisible world being entwined, but the love of God poured out into us through the unity of the Holy Spirit, through and in God the Son, to God the Father. This participation is what gives purpose to our lives. It is why we are created. It is all to participate in the Trinity. The Rublev icon — when you contemplate it, it forms that chalice, and Jesus is there in the center. We, who participate in the bread of life that is Jesus' body, blood, soul, and divinity, are thereby participating in the Trinity. This is why all of it matters so much. There is so much going on here, and everything from our life now has meaning because of this. We who receive Jesus in the Eucharist now know that we are loved, that we are known, that we have a purpose, that we are joined to something greater. We who struggle to find a meaning within suffering — we who have attempted to despair and have many times despaired and repented — now we can affirm Being. We can affirm the blessed Trinity, in which we are participating here and now. This participation should overflow for us.

In his house, there are many rooms. There is welcome for the sinner. There is a place that is set aside for us. We return to the Father — like the prodigal son — joined with Christ in the Paschal mystery, where he who has come forth from the Father has done his own pouring out to enter into creation,

and to take on our sins, our sufferings — to die, to descend into hell, to rise from the dead, and to say, "I will arise and go to my father." He goes — like the prodigal son, but never having sinned — to God the Father. He joins us with himself, and we make that full return through Christ and his passion, death, resurrection, and ascension. We are called into that heavenly liturgy — the worship of God in heaven — which we participate in now by following God's will for us, to enter into that most sacred celebration here and now.

Give thanks

This full return is how we live the Trinitarian life in all aspects — not segmenting it off into some part that we call our faith life. We live our life; our life is inherently Trinitarian, and our life is Trinitarian through the shape of the cross that is traced over us again and again. Living this mystery means living utterly differently, and it needs to be expressed. This pouring-out is the summit — everything that flows down now seeks out the lowest place. God's mercy finds the lowest place within us and in our fallen world. To live this way is to live entirely transformed — but it is not going to involve a depletion of our resources, for we are not living in the world of the problematic but the world of mystery. We have been made for mystery. We are meant for love — our whole existence, our whole lives, is for love. This return we carry out in liturgy, pouring ourselves out. The liturgy is our return to God the Father. What I recommend is to live this life of thanksgiving, to be thankful before God at all times, in all places. Saint Paul says, "Give thanks."

Chapter 4 — Relationship

O Eternal God! O Eternal Trinity! Through the union of Thy divine nature Thou hast made so precious the Blood of Thine only-begotten Son! O eternal Trinity, Thou art as deep a mystery as the sea, in whom the more I seek, the more I find; and the more I find, the more I seek. For even immersed in the depths of Thee, my soul is never satisfied, always famished and hungering for Thee, eternal Trinity, wishing and desiring to see Thee, the True Light.

O eternal Trinity, with the light of understanding I have tasted and seen the depths of Thy mystery and the beauty of Thy creation. In seeing myself in Thee, I have seen that I will become like Thee. O eternal Father, from Thy power and Thy wisdom clearly Thou hast given to me a share of that wisdom which belongs to Thine Only-begotten Son. And truly hast the Holy Spirit, who proceedeth from Thee, Father and Son, given to me the desire to love Thee.

O eternal Trinity, Thou art my maker and I am Thy creation. Illuminated by Thee, I have learned that Thou hast made me a new creation through the Blood of Thine Only-begotten Son because Thou art captivated by love at the beauty of Thy creation.

O eternal Trinity, O Divinity, O unfathomable abyss, O deepest sea, what greater gift couldst Thou give me than Thy very Self? Thou art a fire that burns eternally yet never consumed, a fire that consumes with Thy heat my self-love. Again and again Thou art the fire who taketh away all cold heartedness and illuminateth the mind by Thy light, the light with which Thou hast made me to know Thy truth.

By this mirrored light I know Thou art the highest good, a good above all good, a fortunate good, an incomprehensible good, an unmeasurable good, a beauty above all beauty, a wisdom above all wisdom, for Thou art wisdom itself, the food of angels, the fire of love that Thou givest to man.

Thou art the garment covering our nakedness. Thou feedest the famished with Thy sweetness, a sweetness Thou art from which there is no trace of bitterness. O Eternal Trinity! Amen.

— St. Catherine of Siena (1347–1380), Doctor of the Church

Two Kinds of Knowledge

There are two kinds of knowledge. The first knowledge we are very familiar with. I alluded to it in the earlier conferences, talking about how we deal with problems. It is the knowledge that comes to us through dissecting things that we see, things that we measure, things that we understand. All the different kinds of ologies — biology, philology, geology — all of these kinds of sciences work through understanding the parts and dissecting them, going down deep into them, throwing our minds into these areas and absorbing as much as we can, and then putting them back together to form a cohesive whole. This dissecting approach is how we go about much of our life. It is the realm of the technical, the problematical, and we dissect, we divide, we disjoin. Much of our knowledge comes this way.

St. Thomas Aquinas would quote Aristotle, who said, "Knowledge begins with the senses" — things we can touch and feel. From the senses we derive things we can measure, things we experience on the superficial level, as if they were apart from ourselves, as if we were not implicated in them.

We know things by a likeness. If I see this carpet here, it produces a likeness on me. The more I study that carpet, the more I place that knowledge in me. I understand how to make this carpet, how to deal with the different patterns, how the different production facilities handle the making of a carpet, and I understand it inside and out. My knowledge of it is built up from what I study. That knowledge is based on observation and on study — on making conclusions from it, best practices when it comes to what kind of thread to use and what cleaning processes make most sense. I can build up a knowledge of a carpet. Most knowledge works that way. I could know something in a deeper way, by becoming like the thing I know. A carpet is not the best example of that. That deeper kind of knowing happens in relationships all the time. We might not be able to tell you every single thing about the person we love, but we can know the person. This deeper knowledge — the knowledge that works more with relationships — is to know the person as a whole: that infinite

abyss of existence reaching out to your infinite abyss of existence, the deep calling unto deep. This knowledge is the personal knowledge, the whole knowledge.

The other kind of knowledge is the one that most accords with mystery. It is to treat things not as pieces of a puzzle, something to put together, but as a whole, in its totality. Treating things as wholes is the kind of knowledge that we have as Christians, given to us — the mysteries of our faith, the mysteries of Christ, the events of his life, his death, his resurrection, the mysteries of the rosary, the mysteries of the teachings of the faith. Everything in theology that we understand can be engaged with as mystery, because we are recipients of it. We are participants in our faith. We already engage with this kind of knowledge on some level.

Knowing from the Inside

Those who write and read poetry might be aware that there is a unitive awareness in the poetic imagination — the way in which a poet views the world and approaches things not as pieces, but as wholes. The same might be true of the mystic. The mystic is thrown into the depths of the knowledge of God, but not in a knowledge that we can typically relate to. That knowledge involves the totality of their being with the totality of God's being under some aspect.

Someone who goes through a mystical experience, I am told, is not able to communicate what happened in that experience. St. Paul sheepishly talks about how he knew a man who was caught up to the third heaven — "whether in the body or out of the body I do not know." He cannot really tell much about it, because it is hard to tell. What you know in that way cannot be easily explained.

This kind of knowledge St. Thomas Aquinas calls connatural knowledge. The example he uses to explain how this knowledge works is that of the virtue of chastity. You can understand chastity by observing it and dividing it into its separate parts, understanding how the intellect and the will work together with the passions or against the passions in order to experience and to give and to receive chaste love in

the appropriate context. We can study theology of the body. We can understand these things in all their various ways, and we can understand this virtue well, but someone who lives chastity starts to become like it through their living of it. They might not decipher it and divide it down into its different parts, but someone who understands chastity from the inside has a knowledge that exceeds that of those who study from the outside.

This knowing is called connatural knowledge by St. Thomas Aquinas, because it is knowledge that has become second nature. Virtues become part of us. All knowledge is through a likeness. If I know something — when I divide it into parts and understand the different concepts that go into a field of study — those concepts remain in me. There is a likeness imprinted into my intellect. When we become like something, we bypass the knowledge that comes to us through concepts; instead, we have that likeness imprinted directly on us, on our person. That direct likeness allows us to know and understand on a level wholly different. It is to know and understand with our totality something in its totality.

Marked with the Cross

Mystery is best engaged with this second kind of knowledge. We are imprinted with the Holy Trinity from our baptisms. We are told we are given a mark. Our baptism marks us. We might picture the shape of that mark, of that seal placed in our souls, as cruciform. We reenact that mark every time we make that sign of the cross. It is imprinted on us. It is meant to become so deep that the Trinity is really that by which we understand everything else.

St. Paul says in his letter to the Romans, "Do not be conformed to this world but be transformed by the renewal of your mind." The way in which our minds are renewed is how we come into a unitive awareness, a contemplation of relationship most especially.

Christ Between Us

Christ says, "Where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I in the midst of them." Christ comes in the midst of us. He comes between us — not to separate, for we often use the phrase "between us" as something that shows an obstacle, but to actually connect us.

It really was not until Christ that we became, again — for the first time since Adam and Eve — capable of real communion. For we have a deep communion in Christ — with Christ, but also with each other. Recall the consequences of the fall, how Adam and Eve were disjointed by their original sin. Christ comes between us.

How we cooperate is through taking up our own crosses — the cross of repentance, the cross of healing, the cross of suffering, whatever it might be. We are to participate — to be cooperators in his work. That cooperation is the great thing about the fifth station: Simon of Cyrene helps Jesus carry the cross. St. John Henry Newman says that Christ could have carried the cross by himself — he could have chosen to — but he allowed us to have a share in that work.

I and Thou

Martin Buber was a Jewish philosopher of the 20th century. His great work is called *I and Thou*. It was written in German, and using thou — the older form of you — was emphasized in the English translation to stress not just reverence towards the other — we are really talking about a singular person. When you say "I and you," you could be plural. He wants to say it between a first person singular pronoun and a second person singular pronoun. I and thou.

The Space of the Holy Spirit

In a relationship, there is an I, a thou, a you, and there is a between. There is something that is shared — there is the total gift under the aspect, in a lot of cases, of friendship or other relationships. In that "between" is the space of the Holy Spirit, He who is "between" the Father and the Son. The charity that is in God comes down to us in the theological virtue of charity. We are meant to become more and more loving, to know more and more what love is from the inside out, and then to love others with that same love. This love is expressed in friendship, in any kind of relationship.

I recall Pope Benedict's inaugural homily when he was made Pope in 2005. He said, "It is really so: the purpose of our lives is to reveal God to men. And only where God is seen does life truly begin. Only when we meet the living God in Christ do we know what life is. We are not some casual and meaningless product of evolution. Each of us is the result of a thought of God. Each of us is willed, each of us is loved, each of us is necessary. There is nothing more beautiful than to be surprised by the Gospel, by the encounter with Christ. There is nothing more beautiful than to know Him and to speak to others of our friendship with Him." We are able to really engage in friendship because God has loved us first. He has poured himself out for us when we were not deserving. It is pure gift, and because God has poured himself out, we are able to love each other.

Every Relationship Says Something

All relationships have something that they say about the Trinity. In some way they express that primordial love — that love that was there before the sun and the stars and before we came into being, a love shared constantly, acting out fully between Father, Son, and Holy Spirit from all eternity. That love is the same love with which we now love each other, under different aspects and under different relationships.

We are meant to approach, then, the Trinity under and through these relationships that we have. Motherhood, fatherhood, sonship, even co-workers and others — all these

things now have something in common with God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. There are more ways I am included in my mother — my biological mother — than in some woman I have never met in France. That woman in France is a mystery. For me, my mom is a mystery — I was enclosed within her. I was given life through her. I was nourished by her. There is a connection there that involves me more than some other random person that I have not yet met. Every person is potentially a mystery to me in some way — which is another way of saying another person is potentially someone to be loved. St. Augustine was not wrong to see the Trinity reflected in all aspects of reality, but most especially in us, who are individually and collectively images of God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Encounter, Not Merely Understanding

In this way, we do not merely understand the Trinity. We do not just reduce it to a notion. We do not just divide it up. We do divide it up — under the aspect of theology. We do have notions of the Trinity. We understand it. We can talk about the theological underpinnings of it, and you can read the Catechism, which actually does a great job of giving an overview of a very dense topic. We are not meant to merely understand the Trinity.

Instead, we are to encounter, from the depths of our being, an infinite abyss of existence in another person.

There is a great quote from my uncle Mark's gospel reflection on Trinity Sunday: Marriage enshrines the Trinity. Motherhood expresses it. Fatherhood mirrors it. Friendship touches it. And loneliness, when it does not despair, adores it.

Maybe the way to take this with you is not to ask what the Trinity means, but to ask which of these relationships God is asking you to see as Trinitarian this week — your marriage, your motherhood, your fatherhood, a friendship, or even your loneliness.

Chapter 5 — Intimacy

Too late loved I Thee, O Thou Beauty of ancient days, yet ever new! too late I loved Thee! And behold, Thou wert within, and I abroad, and there I searched for Thee; deformed I, plunging amid those fair forms which Thou hadst made. Thou wert with me, but I was not with Thee. Things held me far from Thee, which, unless they were in Thee, were not at all. Thou calledst, and shoutedst, and burstest my deafness. Thou flashedst, shonest, and scatteredst my blindness. Thou breathedst odours, and I drew in breath and panted for Thee. I tasted, and hunger and thirst. Thou touchedst me, and I burned for Thy peace.

— St. Augustine, Confessions X.27, trans. E. B. Pusey

Being itself

In theology, there is a central concept in talking about God. It is called the analogy of being. There are many who have ideas of God as a being above other beings. Many of us would see God as the greatest of all beings, and because he is the greatest — in fact, he is infinite, omniscient, omnipotent, and all-loving — and therefore he, as the highest of all beings, receives all of our praise and worship.

For many of us, this picture of God as the highest of all beings is our default conception of how God works. We are lesser beings. We are creatures made by God, but God just stands above and beyond all these things. To this we can add his eternality. He is, before time existed, he is, and he always will be. There is no change in God.

There is a fairly common conception of God as the greatest of all beings — all-powerful, all-knowing, without beginning or end — but not Being.

That conception, however, is not the Catholic one. God is not the highest of all beings. God is *Being*. We are *beings*. We participate in him. We have being; he *is* being.

We recall the story of Moses with the burning bush. Moses, wandering in the desert and tending the flock of his father-in-law Jethro, sees on Mount Sinai this bush burning but not being consumed. He goes to the bush, and the bush calls out to him, asking Moses to ask Pharaoh to let his people go. And Moses is not sure about it, but the burning bush — God, from that burning bush, speaks — and Moses is going to listen. But before he leaves, he says, "I need to know your name. So when others ask, 'Who sent you?' I can tell them who it was that sent me." And God, from the burning bush, says, "I AM WHO I AM." Maybe this is God just saying, "I am who I am. Don't worry about it. Just say, 'I am' sent you." Perhaps that was the original context, the original meaning. But "I AM WHO I AM" — we can read back into this and say, God is saying, "I am existence itself. I am being itself." This is Exodus 3:14. Philosophers will say this means that God's essence is his existence. That is not necessarily what is being communicated to Moses — but it fits, because he does not have, he is. And from this revelation we receive the name of God. It was "I am."

Our Lord reiterates this. He has many "I am" statements, especially within the Gospel of John. "I am the door. I am the vine. I am the way, and the truth, and the life." It was on purpose that our Lord said "I am," because this harkens back to the name of God.

What does it mean for God to be existence? This means that God does not have anything. While we say he has, he is. To have means you might not have. To have maybe implies there is something apart from you that is not somehow connected to you. But God does not have, he is. God does not have being. He is being. God does not have love. He is love. God does not have goodness. He is goodness. Whatever he has, he is.

This distinction fundamentally changes how we regard God and how we regard ourselves. We have goodness. God has given it to us. But we are not goodness itself. We have truth.

We can actually ascertain truth with our intellects. We are made for truth. But we are not truth itself. God is.

We, as creatures of God, participate in his being. I mentioned before that everything is gift, everything is positive, everything speaks of God. Even Satan himself, even the one who has rejected God from the first moment of his being and turned his whole self away from God — he still exists. Therefore, he still shares in God. He still shares in God, and therefore he still has goodness — now a goodness of existence, maybe only existence, but he still has existence.

You might ask, what does it mean that we are created out of nothing? Because we are not God. Because — this is the key thing — God is necessary. He *is* existence. God's essence — who he is — and his existence are the same. We have existence. We are not existence. That is a lot to wrap our minds around. Because we participate in God, we are not God. The fact that we were not around from all eternity is one way of saying that we could not be God.

Although true materially, it is somewhat misleading to say God is creating out of nothing. He created out of the abundance of love in the Blessed Trinity. There was nothing, and then there was something, but that something comes from God. It is almost like God is saying, "I'm going to take nothing and add something to it." And from the outside it looks that way, but it is more from God. He wanted to create us. So he did.

We all participate in God. Although not God, everything that is created participates in God. You might think objects do not. By merely existing, they do. But you participate not just by existing, but also by your free choice to cooperate and to respond to God — and that participation is qualitatively higher.

If you sin, are you existing less? In a sense, but it would be more fitting to say sin diminishes the perfection of our participation in the good.

We have goodness, and we also share in God, especially through the gift of his grace. We are made in his image and likeness, so we have a higher share than other things. Many would say, "Well, maybe there is a hierarchy of being, and God is the highest kind of being." But we say, no, God is being itself, and everything else shares in his being. And this sharing in being is why we speak of an analogy of being: everything that has being harkens back to God, who is being. "I AM WHO I AM."

The fifth transcendental

Joseph Ratzinger, in *Introduction to Christianity*, made an interesting claim. We are perhaps familiar with what we call the transcendentals: truth, beauty, goodness, unity — those four. Unity — oneness — that is the original transcendental. God is one. We see that oneness is in a communion of three persons. Transcendentals are something that is in God. It is a characteristic of being that God has in himself and that everything else shares in, in some way. Joseph Ratzinger suggests something that amounts to a fifth transcendental — a fifth characteristic that, because we know it is in God, belongs to all being. What is that fifth transcendental, that characteristic that is in God? We know of it only because God has revealed himself in his inner life of the Trinity. That fifth characteristic is relationality. All beings are relational.

We share in that relationality because we are capable of relationship. We are capable of giving of ourselves and receiving from another under different aspects and different ways, but we give. We do not just communicate words or concepts. We communicate our very selves through those words and through those concepts, through those symbols, through our actions.

We recall that God made us in his image and likeness — male and female he created us. To talk about the theology of the body means to talk about relationship, gift, a response. We are capable of receiving another person in their wholeness and giving back of ourselves in our wholeness, as gifts — not holding on to the gift with strings, pulling it back whenever it

is no longer to our advantage to give. But when we give, we give totally, and we give freely, and we give fruitfully. This is present in every relationship.

No animals besides human beings, the rational, worded animals, can love. Human persons alone among bodily creatures can make a rational, free, morally responsible gift of self.

Because God is relational, because God is being itself, because what he has, he is. We have intellect and will, right? We are able to know and we are able to love. We are able to consume truth in our intellects, and we are able to reach out towards others in love. We say God has knowledge and love. But remember, God does not merely have; what we say God has, God is. God's knowledge is the Son. The Father knows the Son. He is the Word of the Father, spoken from all eternity. And God's love — God's love is the Holy Spirit, the breathing forth of the Father and the Son.

Knowledge and love are in the Trinity as subsistent relations. That theological formulation follows from the principle that what God has, God is: he is always knowing, and he is always loving.

There is a going out with this knowledge. Then there is a fittingness with how the Son, the Word, only begotten Son of God the Father from all eternity, goes out into creation. God had intended to enter creation through the second person of the Holy Trinity all throughout, and to draw all things through Christ, the second person of the Holy Trinity, in the Holy Spirit, back to God the Father. He planned this. For he came down out of love, in a way that fit with who he was in himself. And the Holy Spirit comes down as well, drawing us all together in one spirit, in one body, because what God has, he is.

This is the simplest explanation of God. We look for how we are made in the image and likeness of God, because we are relational, because we are able to know and to love — not

know merely in a divisive way, through sciences and different ologies, but we are able to know each other.

All reality, then, has a share not only in truth, goodness, and beauty, but also relationality. And this relationality makes sense, because we can only speak of a water bottle in relation to my ability to drink from it. There is a relationality with all material things. Even the things that we do not yet see — the tree that falls in the forest with no one around — there is still relationality built into all of these things: that coming together of one thing and another thing. There is relationality built into all material creation, all immaterial creation. All things share in this relationality. This also means that there is no escaping God.

God is in us. In him we move. "We live and move and have our being," St. Paul says. This means, because of the analogy of being, that we cannot escape God. There is no hiding from God. For Adam and Eve, there was no hiding in the Garden of Eden. For us, there is no hiding. We cannot go anywhere to escape him. But also, why would we want to?

This truth works the other way around. Even every thought that we have is known to God. God the Father knows the number of hairs on your head intimately. He knows you. Everything that goes on — every electrical signal discharged in your brain — he knows it. Because everything participates in him. We cannot escape him. God is everything for us. We live in God.

Intimus: the most in

St. Augustine says God is closer to us than we are to ourselves. We are mysteries unto ourselves. We do not know ourselves fully. When we know ourselves and we know God, and we see ourselves as we truly are — the mystery of our worth and our unworthiness — then there is true humility.

We think we know ourselves to some extent, but there are parts of us hidden from us. There are things about us that we do not engage with very often. God knows everything. I am a participating being in God, but God is already closer to me.

Not only is there relationality in how I live out my life — and there is a relationality between my right index finger and my left pinky toe — but there is relationality between God and me. He is closer to me than I am even to myself.

Do you know what the word *intimacy* means and where it comes from? There is a popular idea that intimacy means "into me seeing" — Christopher West says he once heard it said. That pun is helpful, though it is wrong: it is a *false etymology*, never meant as the word's actual origin, but a helpful way to understand into-me-see. And we can see how Adam knew Eve, and the biblical idea of knowing, and that Eve conceived and brought forth the son. That is an intimacy. From the intimacy of husband and wife, children come about. And so into-me-see: you might see who I really am. You might see me in my vulnerability. You might see my shame. You might see who I truly am. I might be affirmed at the level of my being. And there is a true intimacy when that is mutual, to see into each other. There is great truth in this. Into-me-see is a helpful way to understand intimacy. But that is not where the word *intimacy* comes from. It is actually far more simple. In Latin, we have the word *in*, and then the word *interior*, which means "more in" — which we say in English "interior." That is the comparative of the word *in*. And then the superlative, *intimus* — *intimus* — which means "most in." From the word *intimus*, we derive the word *intimacy*.

God is intimate with us. He is the most in. He is closer to us than we are to ourselves.

Contemplate him in the holy Eucharist, and we become like him — for we shall see him as he really is. We become like God, and our knowledge of God is not merely from study — sometimes aided by our study — but it becomes the likeness of God on our souls. We who live godly lives know God from the inside — not from the outside in, but from the inside out.

And the saints who have been purified through their long periods of suffering — God will sometimes grant to them particular blessings of knowing him in ways that cannot be

communicated. *Fire Within* is a great book by Thomas Dubay, discussing the advancement in the spiritual life from a beginner — where a lot of us are — to ultimately being united with God. In that state of being united with God, there is a likeness in our soul. It can maybe be somewhat communicated poetically. John of the Cross, who lived much of his life in the stage of unitive wholeness with God, would communicate to us through poems. The poetic imagination works in this sort of wholeness — not grasping after the small details, deciphered and put together, but the whole of the thing. Mystical knowledge works in this way, and our knowledge of God will work in this way as well, even if we are merely in the beginner stage.

The friend already home

St. John Henry Newman, reflecting on Advent and this idea of waiting for Christ, gave an analogy to explain what he means by waiting or watching. The analogy is this: you are waiting for a friend to arrive, and all your thoughts and all your heart are fixed on that friend; you have everything ready in your house, everything prepared for his coming, and now you are waiting, and maybe he is delayed. But that does not mean you are distracted and go somewhere else. Your whole being is fixed on waiting for the coming of this friend.

This is the attitude all of us should have in Advent — and, of course, in all times. We are waiting for Christ. We are waiting for him to come again. He who is coming, always coming into this world, who has come in the incarnation, who is with us always, even at the close of the age, who is with us in the Eucharist, who is with us when two or three are gathered in his name. We are always waiting for him. He is always coming.

To alter the analogy slightly: if you are waiting for a friend, and perhaps you become distracted, or perhaps you need to attend to some errand, or because you are preparing for his coming you go out to Giant Eagle to pick up groceries and other things needed for his visit. But when you come back to your house, you are horrified. There is your friend's car

parked in your driveway. You go to the front door. You go in, and you see your friend already sitting on your couch.

What would you say to such a friend? "How the heck did you get in? You are no longer my friend. You violated my privacy. You came when I was gone. That is not socially acceptable. You should have waited in your car until I returned."

Or a true friend — if we have been waiting for him — we would say to him, "Welcome. I'm glad you made yourself at home."

This welcome is more fitting for how God comes to us in intimacy.

When we think about the closeness of God to us — God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, all three already dwell within us. The Holy Spirit dwells within — we are a temple of the Holy Spirit. The Father hears us from our inner room. Christ's Sacred Heart beats with our hearts. God is closer to us than we are to ourselves.

In the incarnation, and in our configuration to Christ, we have entered into the love of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. We have access now to that love within us. He has made a home within us.

Christ resting in the storm

We look for him in created things. We try to find God in created beauty — beauty that is derivative, that shares in God's beauty, but is not Beauty itself with a capital B. Meanwhile, he was within us, always closer to us than we are to ourselves.

St. Augustine said that when Christ ascended into heaven, he ascended from the apostles' eyes so they might turn towards their hearts and find him there, because within us, God rests.

We might think it is very hard for God to rest in my soul, because it seems my experience has told me otherwise. In my soul, there is little rest. There is constant anxiety. There is

constant fear, maybe even anger. There is shame, there is guilt. How could God be there already?

Maybe mostly for our benefit, once, when the apostles were in the boat, a great storm came upon them, and these experienced fishermen were afraid for their lives. They who had already weathered many storms — now, this was the big one. This was going to claim their lives. But where is Christ in this? He is there on a cushion, sleeping. How is it that when the boat is being rocked about, water is entering in, there is danger of being capsized, or the ship breaking under the waves, Christ is there, sleeping? Christ rests in our souls. And he likes to rest in our souls when there is the most amount of chaos.

He is there, always, sustaining us in being. "Each one of us is the result of a thought of God," Pope Benedict said. If God ever ceased to think about us, we would not exist. We would have no past, no present, no future. He who is being itself is always holding on to us, loving us. And in us, in our souls, in our hearts, he is resting.

God is with us. Jesus is Emmanuel, God with us. Yet we still want to say to him, "Teacher, do you not care if we perish?" Just as we would want to say to the friend who made himself at home, "Do you not care that I was stressed about many things?"

Even in every kind of consternation, every stress, every anxiety, every time we move to anger or resentment, every wound that we feel — the Holy Spirit, Christ the Son, the Father — they are all resting within us, like Christ on the boat in the Sea of Galilee, sleeping on a cushion in the midst of a storm. God rests in us. He waits for us patiently, for we are his. We already live and move and have our being in him (Acts 17:28). He desires us for himself. He wants us to be made more and more like him. He waits for our silent adoration. He waits for us to just be with him — to let us know that we are known, that we are loved, that he is drawing us to himself in every time and in every place. God draws

close to us. Let God — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — love you from the inside out.

Martha, Mary, and the one thing

We want to be like Martha. "Lord, do you not care that my sister has left me to serve alone? Tell her then to help me." Our Lord might answer, "Martha, Martha, you are anxious and troubled by many things, but one thing is necessary, and Mary has chosen the better part."

Our Lord might say: Mary, the sister of Martha, has been resting with me. She has been listening to me in the chaos of this home. She is giving me the greatest hospitality, like Abraham and Sarah, but even more so. Yes, I care for you, and I want you to have the same thing. I want you to have the better part, the one thing. And I want to tell you something about who I am. For God the Son reveals himself, and he speaks of the Father only, for he only has the Father to speak of, because everything he has comes from the Father. He is the Father's, and the Father is his. And then from their love comes the Holy Spirit. Martha, I want you to also know who I am: the one thing necessary — that one thing is three — three persons in one God.

This God — who created in six days and rested on the seventh — desires to rest in you, in your hearts and your souls. Never mind the chaos. Never mind the storms. I am with you.

The cross: the Trinity's embrace

What does Christ speak to us of the love of God — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit? He enters into our sufferings in a way so obvious that we miss it every time we look upon a crucifix: he who has shouldered our burdens and taken the cross upon himself has suffered every one of our sufferings. He cries out, "Father, into your hands, I commit my spirit." And he sends forth his spirit. The cross is an image of the Trinity. The cross is the Trinity embracing us.

One of you, after my first talk, discussing the sign of the cross, said, "The sign of the cross is a hug from the Holy Trinity." In

this way, God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, is closer to us than we are to ourselves. Let him love you. Let him embrace you. Let him hug you. Respond by welcoming him in your hearts and letting that love spread to others.

Chapter 6 — Evangelization

Dear Jesus, help me to spread your fragrance everywhere I go. Flood my soul with your Spirit and life. Penetrate and possess my whole being so utterly that my life may only be a radiance of yours. Shine through me and be so in me that every soul I come in contact with may feel your presence in my soul. Let them look up and see no longer me, but only Jesus. Stay with me, and then I shall begin to shine as you shine, so to shine as to be a light to others. The light, O Jesus, will be for all from you. None of it will be mine. It will be you shining on others through me. Let me praise you the way you love best, by shining on those around me. Let me preach you without preaching, not by words but by example, by the catching force of the sympathetic influence of what I do, the evident fullness of the love my heart bears to you. Amen.

— St. John Henry Newman

Back to St. Patrick

This final chapter circles back to where we started, talking about St. Patrick and his evangelization of the people of Ireland.

According to tradition, St. Patrick had blessed a fire in the 400s that no attempts by the Druid pagans could extinguish. That fire kept burning and burned brightly — a witness against the pagans, but more importantly, a witness of God's love; the fire was meant to go forth and spread.

The words that send us to evangelize come from our Lord before he ascended into heaven, when he told his apostles: "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the

Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you; and behold, I am with you always, to the close of the age."

There has been an evangelizing impulse from the beginning, from the gift of the Holy Trinity given to us. Because we are baptized into Christ, because we receive the divine life of the blessed three in one, we are impelled to go outwards.

The Church's own canon law recognizes this: all of us, by virtue of baptism and confirmation, are by nature missionary.

This missionary nature derives from our Lord's teaching: the greatest commandment is to love God, and the second is like it — to love your neighbor as yourself. The perfection of that commandment is to love one another as I have loved you. What has been poured into us cannot be contained. If we have now shared in the mystery of the Holy Trinity, the mystery is not ours alone; it is meant to go out and make us evangelize all people.

And going back to the little rectangle on Rublev's Trinity icon — it may represent, as we saw, the four corners of the world. The message of the Trinitarian love of God is meant to go out.

Owning the mystery

We think about evangelizing those who do not yet know Christianity, or who do not know it well, and we run into an awkward question. We want to tell them about Jesus. We want to tell them that Jesus died for their sins — that he not only died for us, but rose from the dead and ascended to the Father. All of this is well and good, but to anyone hearing it, it is a problem. For — you are saying Jesus is God? Yes. But does not Jesus have a God? Is he just the Son of God? Are there two gods? What is going on with that?

We run into the problem of the Trinity right away, anytime we try to evangelize and catechize as part of that work, and it is an awkward thing. Do we try to work around it? Do we

insist there is one God and just say, "Don't worry about that — it's a mystery"?

Some from the outside might say, "How is this altogether different from those people who believe in multiple gods? It seems that you want to have your cake and eat it too." Or maybe, "How is this different from the Mormons, who believe the Father and Son are separate divine beings, and that the faithful may one day become gods? How is this different? For don't you, as Christians, believe that you will become like God? Did not one of your early Christian saints — St. Athanasius — say, 'For the Son of God became man so that we might become God'?"

What do we do with this objection? We need to take ownership of it. We need to acknowledge that the Trinitarian mystery of God is something that actually gives us greater access to God. He is not just transcendent, far away; he is immanent — close to us, within us, the most within us. He is intimate with us.

Once we even begin to understand the Trinity — even with just helpful images — the fact that some things can be one and three, the relationality between beings, between people, between persons, the image of the Trinity expressed in marriage, where husband and wife give themselves so totally to each other that a third person comes forth in fruitfulness — all of this helps us see that there is a Trinitarian structure to our relationships.

Christ in the poor

It is fitting that the prayer I said at the beginning is from St. John Henry Newman, and it was a favorite prayer of Mother Teresa. As she went out and encountered Christ in the poorest of the poor, she lived out Matthew 25. "How, Lord, when did we see you hungry and give you food, and thirsty and give you drink? When did we see you naked and clothe you, and find you in prison and visit you?" And our Lord said, "Amen. Whatever you did for the least of my brothers, you did for me."

St. Paul was taught by his conversion. "Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?" "Who are you, Lord?" "I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting." St. Paul recognized that in those who suffer, Christ is present. Christ is with us in the poor. He is with us in our poverty.

And when Mother Teresa went out to serve the poorest of the poor, she could not help but see Christ in them. It gives me great edification to know that she loved this prayer of St. John Henry Newman so much that when people hear it — this prayer of "help me to spread your fragrance everywhere I go" — they think it is Mother Teresa's, because she prayed it so often. Yet it actually belongs to a rather intellectual saint of the nineteenth century, an Oratorian priest named John Henry Newman.

Other Christs

But we are meant for others to see only Jesus in us, so that we might shine out with his light. Mother Teresa understood intuitively that we are to be Christ to Christ. We are to be as Jesus to them. We are other Christs — not just because we belong to Christ and are called Christians, but because we are Christ. We are the extension of Christ in this world.

We, who have been incorporated into his body through the Holy Eucharist, are his hands and his feet going out into the world. We serve others as Christ's body ourselves.

Here we start to see a positive feedback loop. It is Christ serving Christ. We who give of ourselves so fully to this work of evangelization, this work of the corporal works of mercy, serve Christ. They are built up, and they too are transformed. They might go forth and also love Christ and others. It is a chain reaction. In an atomic bomb, the chain reaction would result in a massive explosion of megatons of TNT. For us, it is evangelization.

We serve Christ, and as Christ, everyone we serve encounters the gospel. They encounter Christ, and they know they are loved. The two great desires of our heart are to be known and

to be loved. How could they go forth without loving others with that same love?

Nothing more beautiful

And so the chain reaction goes into the four corners of the world: this totality of our witness, our own martyrdom, our giving of ourselves so fully over to Christ. The witness is a gift never meant to be extinguished within us.

Who, having a light, puts it under a basket? No, you put it on a lampstand to shine out. "You are the light of the world," Christ says. He also says, "I am the light of the world." Both of these are true: we are the light of the world because we are other Christs. We shine out with the same light so that others might only see him, and from that one light, the light is spread.

Christ came that we might have life and have it abundantly. He came to set the world on fire, and how he wished it were already ablaze!

We remember how St. Ignatius of Loyola would say to his missionaries, the Jesuits of the sixteenth century, as they were sent out into the four corners of the world to spread the gospel to people who had never heard it: "Go, set the world on fire." We burn with that love, that catching force of sympathetic influence, so that others might see Christ in us and be influenced by it.

The Easter flame

The way we evangelize the love of the Trinity is the same way the light is spread at the Easter Vigil, the mother of all vigils, when the priest blesses the fire, the sacred fire. Lifting it up and saying, "Lumen Christi" — the light of Christ — and from that one flame go forth all the different tapers, all the little candles around the church. The church that was in darkness is now filled with the light. Each of us carries in ourselves the flame of Christ in our hearts, symbolized by the candle that we carry. Now it is kept blazing and is meant not to be confined to that church, but to go out from there.

Missa est: "It has been sent"

At the end of every Mass, we hear: "Go forth, the Mass is ended." *Ite, missa est.* "Ite" means go. Go out. What happened here is not meant to be confined here. The liturgy is meant to envelop all of creation. It is cosmic in its proportions. Christ comes so that all things might be recapitulated in him, might be united in him — all things. Christ says in the book of Revelation, "Behold, I make all things new."

"The Mass is ended" is actually a questionable translation. "*Missa est*" does not mean "the Mass has ended." According to one older reading — that of the nineteenth-century liturgical scholar, Prosper Guéranger — it means "it has been sent." What has been sent? Sometimes people translate it as "be sent" — "go and be sent." Some priests will explain that "missa est" means "be sent" — "go and be sent, be sent, go out into the world, be sent into the world." However, it does not quite mean that; the grammar of *missa est* means something has been sent.

What has been sent? Who has it been sent to? What has been sent is the offering of Christ, the *Eucharistia* — the thanksgiving, the oblation, the full gift of himself. Who has it been sent to? We might think that the Mass is offered to us. It is not primarily offered to us. The Mass is our offering of Christ to the Father. Christ has been offered to the Father. The Mass is not just Jesus coming down to us in the Eucharist. The Mass is that Jesus comes, and he goes — he goes out from the Father down to us, and he goes back to the Father. What he does in salvation — in becoming incarnate and dying and rising and ascending — he does in the Mass. He has been sent back to the Father.

We, as Christians, as other Christs, are meant to pattern our lives after that heavenly liturgy. We are meant to go forth and be sent, as Christ was sent, to the Father. It has been sent, it has been offered, and we are now to do likewise in the way we live our lives. The liturgy does not end with the last words of the Mass, with the last song we sing. The liturgy goes onwards

in our hearts, where we can always pray to the Father in secret and make offerings of ourselves.

What Christ does in the Mass is not just a mystery about the second person of the Holy Trinity; it is a mystery of all three persons. It is through Christ, with Christ, in Christ, to God the almighty Father, in the unity of the Holy Spirit, to whom all praise and glory belongs forever and ever. That mystery is meant to be lived by us now, and as we go forth. Mass is not a one-time thing, not something we merely do for half an hour or forty-five minutes a day and then leave behind. It is how we live our lives. The source and summit of our lives is also how we live our evangelization.

God's unselfish love, his *agape*, has been poured out, and from it, in its excess, in its generosity, in its abundance, all things were created. That *agape* poured out now finds its response in us in our *Eucharistia*. The liturgy is the pouring out of God — his agape — and our Eucharistia, our thanksgiving in Christ, coming together. And now this response is meant to spread outwards. We are to be the light to the world.

Living it, not just teaching it

In fact, not just how we teach but how we live needs to be relational. We think of it mostly in terms of teaching, and we think there is right teaching and there is wrong teaching. And those who espouse right teaching — we are in that group, in that same tribe. That group is where we are comfortable, where we are supported. They will say things we will most likely agree with, and therefore we will be around those people. Those people who say false teachings, we will reject. We will separate them. They do not matter. They are problems to be solved — or, more often, problems to be ignored. In this way of focusing only on teaching, we fall into rejecting others and rejecting the mystery — not allowing the story they have, of brokenness and error, to be completed by Christ with the mercy of God.

Do not just teach the Trinity. To live the Trinity means to love them as persons. We are tempted to have that dividing

line — there is us and them. But there is no peace in thinking this way; it is the peace the world gives. As Fr. Michael often says, it is the peace that comes from the unity of everyone minus one. It is how we can scapegoat, but it is not how we are to live.

The mystery of the Trinity does embrace all. All things make sense by it. All persons are meant to be included in it — not just by nature, but by grace as well. To live from the love of the Trinity, then, means to love all those — even those who hate us — as our Lord says: "Blessed are you when men revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account." We can share that blessedness if we make sure to give of ourselves and be truly vulnerable.

Tell everyone

How could we contain this mystery in us? If you have been changed by this retreat, if you have been transformed by the renewal of your mind, you will not let it just stay with you. If the Trinity is the best-kept secret of our faith, as Fr. James Dominic Brent calls it, then tell everyone. The mystery is not meant to be confined, not meant to be held back; it is meant to be the leading point, the arrow of our evangelization.

There is nothing to be ashamed of in the Trinity, and nothing to hide away and say, "I can't understand it, neither can you, but just know that Jesus loves you." Yes, Jesus loves you, but he wants you to be part of him, incorporated into his body, sharing in his very being, and to be part of the Holy Trinity with, through, and in him.

We are made from love. God created everything out of love in order to draw all things to himself, and that drawing is meant to include us. We who are embraced by the very Trinity want others to share in that embrace also. Do not hide this away. The Trinity should be spilling out of our thoughts, out of our words, out of our actions — not just out of the words, as though we reduce everything to words. No, we show it forth.

I love how Catholics — because we understand mystery, because we understand that we are created in God's image

and likeness and actually share his being by creation, and by redemption are given his grace, his inner life becoming our life as well — do not merely tell, but show. We show it by the evident force, the catching force of our sympathetic influence, our care for others, because we see Christ in every single person we encounter, so that no one is a mere mortal, as C.S. Lewis would say, but everyone, as St. John Henry Newman says, is "an infinite abyss of existence."

We are not meant to remain empty abysses. We are meant to be filled with the fire of God's love. We are meant to share in his being. Christ chooses to do that through us. What is his favorite way, the way he loves best, to share the glory of God — Father, Son, Holy Spirit — but by us shining on those around us, those he has given for us to love.

Floodgates

In every single person we can see the mystery of Christ and his redemption, his yearning for us. Some of us are waiting to be activated. Some of us are dead in our sins, waiting for Christ to rise again and go to the Father. Christ has come to us in our brokenness and has forgiven us our sins — our venial sins even in the holy Eucharist, and our mortal sins through the sacrament of confession. All of us, though, are meant to share in that divine life.

Let us not hold that mercy back. Let us open the floodgates of God's mercy and love into this fallen world. Let him love us. Let the waves and the billows, the torrents, all wash over us. In the chaos of this life, let us find Christ within, already resting in our souls, and be impelled by him, especially in his gift of the Holy Eucharist, to go forth.

We are now to spread mercy to everyone else as well, and to go forth and welcome — just as we welcome Christ in our own hearts — those who most reject us, those we would rather protect ourselves from. Welcome, then, with forgiveness; welcome them with compassion, to share in their own sufferings, and then to help draw them. We might be the means by which others encounter the same Trinitarian love. Our baptisms are not meant to terminate within us. They are

meant to impel us forward as well, to make disciples of all nations, so that others might be baptized in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit.

Let Christ love us. Let him love others through us. May we all be caught up in that love that made the sun and the stars, and be joined with Christ and the Father and the Holy Spirit in the heavenly liturgy to come.

Epilogue — Engineering Mystery

This talk was given at a retreat for engineering students.

The Engineering Worldview

Without realizing it, all of us have a way of viewing the world: an imaginative vision, a lens through which everything comes, and we experience it — adding labels to it, quantifying, qualifying, calculating. There is also an engineering worldview, a way of looking at the world as engineers. I was very much of the engineering worldview. It was a safe way of thinking for me, especially in high school.

I found out that I liked physics. Physics you can trust. Math you can trust. It does not lie to you. It does not hurt you. I found I could throw myself into physics problems, and it became a way of understanding the world. I could understand it through mathematical equations. It was a way of calculating rather than reflecting and resting.

One part of living in the engineering worldview was that I liked to optimize. Everything was an optimization problem. I desired efficiency. I would not waste effort. Why would I study for an exam more than I needed to? I could know the minimum amount I had to study to get the grade that I desired, and then I would study that amount, and then I would waste the rest of the time in dissipation. That was my strategy in high school, and for the most part it actually worked. Laziness was a huge motivator for me, because I could control the things I could control. The things I could not control, I did not have to worry about, because I could go off and be an engineer.

An Optimized Vocation

I was blessed to be from a large Catholic family. I am the eighth of fourteen children. When I was in high school, I had a deepened experience of the love of God for me — it came at a Franciscan youth conference after my junior year, where the desire to pray was placed on me. The desire to do God's will was there for me.

But I had my life mostly set. I desired to be an engineer. I could use the physics that I was learning, and I could apply it to making things. My high school years became about optimizing my high school experience so that when I arrived at college, I could study engineering in an even more efficient way. That meant taking AP classes on the advice of my older siblings, who had done engineering before me. I could learn from them about what to do and what not to do, and I would be able to enter college with at least a semester's worth of credits under my belt.

There was really only one option for me for college, and that was the University of Pittsburgh — because why would I waste my time applying somewhere else if I did not want to go there? I was lazy. Why would I care if some other school wanted to accept me? I only had one place I wanted to go. I remember Franciscan University reached out to me and invited me to apply, and I said, "You don't have an engineering program. If you had an engineering program, I would go there. But you don't. So I'm going to go to the University of Pittsburgh. If I was going to be a priest, I'd go to Franciscan."

You see how that worked out?

When I went to the University of Pittsburgh, I had a desire to be an engineer. I put my identity in my work. I studied because I was told that freshman engineering was grueling. And they told us we had to make a choice. You either have friends, or you are an engineer. You can party on weekends, but there are other programs for you in the arts and sciences. Liberal arts? Yes, do that. That way you can party. I threw myself into it. But I also had a desire at the same time to pray,

to enter into the interior life. I knew that was lacking in me. I knew that many of my years and my youth were wasted away in utter dissipation. It was not YouTube then, but the beginnings of social media — I had a MySpace account. I was friends with Tom from MySpace, as was everyone. The dissipation was mostly watching TV, watching movies, letting my life just disappear, staying up late doing nothing.

I did not like this. I wanted the interior life, and I did not realize what it was. I wanted to pray. When I came to the Franciscan youth conference during high school, I bought my first brown scapular and was invested. I thought, I need to pray the rosary every day, because if I do not, it does not count, and I am living a lie — which is a little bit true. I did not pray the rosary, I do not think, at all during my senior year. I started a few times, and I thought, I just cannot do it. It is too much, because it was the weight of all of this — a lot of suffering, a lot of woundedness. But I never managed to actually pray.

But I thought — college — I can start these habits. I had a little pocket version of the *Imitation of Christ*, and I snuck off to the library to read it between classes, back before I actually had any kind of work. I started going to Mass once a week, in addition to Sunday Mass — I always went to Sunday Mass — and I stayed after and had dinner with my brother. We had deep conversations. I started to do Eucharistic Adoration. First, I was filling up the time with some book that told me what to pray, just to carry me through that hour. And more and more I opened up towards silence, the resting, and the embrace of Christ. As this went on, I found a desire in me.

The priests who had influenced me so much — now that I was in college, the priests of the Oratory, with whom I shared life — let me see how they lived and how they prayed. They were normal. I wanted to be like them. I started serving Mass, which was a ploy to bring me to Mass more than just one extra time a week. But it worked. I found I wanted to be on the altar. I saw that desire in me grow.

During my sophomore year — having taken upon myself by that time a daily rosary, almost daily Mass, almost daily holy hour — I went to my uncle, who was a priest. I said, "Hey, Uncle Mark, what do I do? I'm thinking maybe priesthood." And he said, "I have an idea for you. Not this summer, but the summer after — Trinity Sunday, that's the Sunday after Pentecost — you need to make a decision. Right now you're broadly discerning, and that makes sense for where you are in life. You're nineteen years old. But you need to decide whether you're going to go from discerning to discerning of the priesthood. And that's the time you're going to make that decision."

He was telling me this — it was December of 2008 — and he was talking about a year and a half from then. I said, "Uncle Mark, you need to hear me out. I've been going to Mass every day, and I want to be there. I've been praying the Rosary. I've been doing the Holy Hours. I actually really desire this. And you're the first person I've told about this desire, because I kept it so hidden. Because if you let someone know about it, you might get hurt."

He said, "Oh, let's up this a little bit. Not a year and a half from now, but this summer. Come Trinity Sunday, the Sunday after Pentecost, you need to make a decision. Are you going to discern the priesthood, or are you going to just go on discerning? That's when you're going to make the decision. In the meantime, continue doing what you're doing."

That was the advice I was given. Come Trinity Sunday — a very important day — I made the decision, peacefully. I told my father. He was thrilled. "Oh, my son? A priest? Oh no — wow, that's amazing. Yes, wow, yes." And my mom said, "Oh, but you were such a good engineer." That summer, I dropped out of all my engineering classes, took philosophy classes, switched my major to philosophy — I was told I had enough credits that I had an engineering minor in electrical engineering — and I would graduate two years later with a degree in philosophy, and join the Oratory of the same priest who had influenced me during my undergrad.

Now, as a priest, I work in campus ministry to give back to the students at Pitt, CMU, and Chatham.

That engineering worldview was very important to me as a high schooler and as a college student, but the worldview is not what it means to be transformed in Christ. It is how the world looks at things, how this age looks at things. We reduce ourselves to calculators, to robots, so easily replaced by artificial intelligence. We forget what it means to be human. We forget what it means to be a son or daughter of God the Father.

The Viewer Is Part of It

I looked at the world in a technical frame of mind — the engineering worldview: to be measured, calculated, analyzed, kept at a distance — because keeping things at a distance is safe, and I know I will not be wrong, because I can trust the science. I would never have to make that mistake of thinking that someone cared about me when they did not.

Recall how Gabriel Marcel said that mystery, properly speaking, implicates the viewer. We are part of it.

Think of the observer effect in quantum physics. When you go to measure something — the effect does not matter on the macro level, but it matters on the micro and the nano level — the means by which you measure it actually affect the thing you are measuring. You cannot get an accurate, precise measurement, because the probe you are using comes into contact with it. And if you had a qubit — you know about quantum computers — a qubit exists in a superposition of zero and one, but once you measure it, it defaults to a zero or a one. The act of measuring it affects it. It seems that on the quantum physics level, we understand that we are part of the experiment. We are not separate from it.

A Solar Flare of Love

God is a mystery, not because we cannot understand God, but because God overwhelms us. The being that we have is a participation in God, who is capital-B Being. God does not have being; he is being. You cannot separate yourself from that participation. You can study it theologically or philosophically, but you could also experience it as mystery, where you enter into it.

Not only is God a mystery — the Trinity is a mystery. There is so much to understand about the Trinity. It overwhelms our ability to think. We cannot possibly grasp it. You try to stare into the Trinity, and it is like staring into the sun. We can distinguish the notions, the properties, the relations, the processions — but we are always going to be overwhelmed by it. What is the proper response to the Trinity? Worship.

Through worship, we are included in this mystery — this mystery that is like a solar flare out of the love of God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. Out of all things that were created — the excess, the abundance of God's love spilled out and strewn across the sky — God looked for someone who would share in his image and likeness, who could respond, who could reflect him, who could make a total gift of themselves, who could receive others. We are thus included in the mystery of creation, implicated in its mystery. When we study creation, we are studying ourselves in the process. We are examining the echo of the Trinity.

This Holy Trinity is not something merely studied. Rather, marriage enshrines it. Motherhood expresses it. Fatherhood mirrors it. Friendship touches it. Loneliness, when it does not despair, adores it — the fivefold litany of my uncle Mark's reflection.

The Invisible World and the Sacraments

The Trinity is lived — to glorify God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — because we are included in that mystery. This inclusion is the fundamentally Christian worldview. We understand mystery. We see that mere matter is not mere matter. The things that we see around us are teeming with the life hidden from us. The visible world — that which we can analyze, calculate, measure — communicates the invisible world.

St. John Henry Newman — when he was a child, he said that he thought the invisible world was more real to him than the visible world: that the visible world was like a shroud placed over us, and that the invisible world was where he truly felt at home — the world of God, the world of angels. As children, we see this more intuitively, and we learn to forget about the invisible world.

This takes on another dimension for us as Catholics, because when we take mere matter, it becomes transformed — sacramentally, of course, in the seven sacraments; preeminently in the sacrament of the Holy Eucharist: mere bread and wine transubstantiated into the body and blood, soul and divinity of Christ. This becomes a vehicle of grace. The life of God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — his indwelling — comes to us powerfully through the sacraments.

When you are baptized, and the waters pour over your head in the threefold invocation — "I baptize you in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit" — what is symbolized by that action happens. You are transformed. You are a beloved daughter, a beloved son, from that moment onwards, of God the Father. You live your whole life now, embraced by God the Father.

Intimacy — The Most In

As you go on through life, you can have the confidence that St. Thérèse of Lisieux too had. She said, in her Last Conversations, that even if she were to commit the worst sin, she could throw herself into the arms of God, her Father, and be confident that he would catch her. This confidence means living differently, because we live in the mystery of the love of God for us.

One way to enter into the mystery is silence. God the Father spoke one word from all eternity — St. John of the Cross says — and that word was his Son, and that word was uttered in silence. If we are to receive that word, we are to receive it in silence.

It is in the silence of the heart that Christ instructs us to go. He says: when you pray, do not be like the hypocrites who like to stand on street corners and marketplaces. Rather, when you pray, go into your inner room, close the door, and your Father who hears in secret will reward you. Of course, Christ can be referring to your actual inner room — the place that is cut off from everyone else — but he is also referring to the inner room of your heart. You go into that place, and God the Father hears you.

Recall the meaning of the word "intimacy." It comes from a Latin word — *intimus*. It is a superlative: *in*, *interior*, *intimus* — the most in. Intimacy means that when we have intimacy with God, he is most interior to ourselves — the truth we met earlier in the chapter on intimacy.

St. Augustine said he looked for God outside of himself, looking to fill himself up with the things of this world. But at last, he looked into his heart, and he found God there. "Too late loved I Thee, O Thou Beauty of ancient days, yet ever new! too late I loved Thee! ... Thou hast made us for Thyself, and our heart is restless, until it repose in Thee." God envelops us with the mystery of his love. His Trinitarian love spills out to us. We are included in that love. He is more intimate. He is closer to me than I am to myself.

Every year on the feast day of St. Augustine, if you go on Instagram — which I do not ever recommend — you will find that some Catholic person likes to quote something St. Augustine apparently said: "I looked into my deepest wound, and there I saw your glory, and it dazzled me." God rests in those deepest, darkest places in our hearts — those places we want to forget about, places where I have been hurt, where I have not received love. God is already there. As much as we invite him in, as much as we try to make him show up, he is already loving us.

God Has Already Loved You

This is love — not that we have loved God, St. John says — not that we have proved to God that we loved him, that we have gone out of our way and made sure we loved him first. No. "In this is love, not that we loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the expiation for our sins." God is already loving us. He has taken the initiative. He is not waiting around for us to prove ourselves.

Part of the engineering worldview is that we have to work and to have success in order to make any kind of progress. The problem with school is you have to earn your good grades. You go into your work, and you have to do what your boss expects of you. You have to live up to some standard of performance. And in that way you might be rewarded with some kind of raise. That makes sense; it is the basic reward system we have. It is the worldview of this age — being conformed to this age rather than transformed by the renewal of your mind. For God has already loved you. You do not have to do anything to prove it. How we live that out, then, is that we receive that love, and we respond.

We are meant to respond to the gift, to the mystery of God. We are meant to respond to him for redeeming us. We are meant to respond — with, through, and in Christ, the second person of the Holy Trinity — to God the Father in the Holy Spirit. The way we do that is through the body of Christ — the body of Christ, his bride, the Church. When we follow the rules, when we go to Mass, we hear readings that are

themselves a prayer offered to God. When we give ourselves over to God in the Offertory, we give ourselves over to him in Holy Communion — he who gives himself so totally over to us — and we are caught up in a higher cycle of giving.

In systems engineering, a feedback loop is an output fed back into its own input. There are positive and negative feedback loops. A negative feedback loop is typically the more desirable one. Negative feedback loops are safe. In the spiritual life, however, we actually want to be caught up in a positive feedback loop — the loop we met earlier in this book as the positive feedback loop of grace. We want the output to be fed back into the input and to increase things exponentially. In the liturgy, we are offering ourselves to God, who offers himself to us.

Now, we know at least enough theology of the body to know about the law of the gift, as it is commonly called. The law of the gift means that when you give something away, you do not lose it; you actually gain. It is a spiritual life hack.

For if you give of yourself, you end up gaining everything of yourself. It is only in a sincere gift of oneself, the Second Vatican Council says, that man finds himself. If you give yourself away, so totally over to God, you gain. You feed that output back into the input. You give everything of yourself over to God, and you have already gained so much that you give more back to God — whether that is in the expressions of devotion, whether it is a willingness to suffer, union with Christ crucified, whether it is that friend you bring along the way — you give more back to God. Every day when you offer yourself to God, you make that little act of self-offering — giving your day, giving your work, giving your thoughts, your words, your actions, over to God, whether through a morning offering or the prayer of the Church, or a desire to go to Mass.

What typically happens is that we hold back. We do not want to give ourselves. We think it is not safe. It might get out of control. Faith, hope, and love — the greatest of these is love. These three are theological virtues: because they go towards

God, they do not admit of excess. Whereas in something like courage, you might say too much courage is foolhardiness. But too much faith — there is no such thing. Too much hope — there is no such thing. Too much love — there is no such thing.

We can be caught up in the mystery of God's love again and again, and completely offer ourselves in our totality, in our capacity to give of ourselves — not in mere contracts and little bits of ourselves, siphoning off just the smallest amounts in order to be safe — when we give our whole selves in our poverty. It is like the woman, the widow, who gave only two small coins in the treasury. Our Lord, on the eve of his passion, said of her that she had given more than everyone else. Everyone else gave of their excess. She gave from her poverty — her whole livelihood. When we give, we give similarly. We give poorly.

One more thing that challenges the engineering worldview: you have heard the expression, "Whatever is worth doing is worth doing well." But some of you are familiar with G.K. Chesterton. He said, "If a thing is worth doing, it is worth doing badly." I would correct Chesterton here. Anything worth doing is worth doing *poorly*. For if it is worth doing, it is worth doing. Conversely we find ourselves caught up in that aphorism — "whatever is worth doing is worth doing well" — and we do not even do it.

I go back to myself as a senior in high school, when I wanted to pray. I had opportunities to pray so much, but instead I listened to music. Instead I would just sit on a couch. Instead I would just fill up my time with whatever I could, in order to not have to face myself. But maybe just praying poorly would have been the move to make at that time. Whatever is worth doing is worth doing poorly.

In fact, in this setting of gift and mystery, whatever is worth doing is worth doing out of your poverty. Give of yourself so totally that you become poor in the process. The lovely Franciscan emphasis on the poverty of St. Francis — Franciscan spirituality — means that poverty is essential to

giving. You make yourself poor, and in making yourself poor, you gain everything.

The Feed and the Feasts

We have a God who is a loving Father who will not deprive you of what you are meant to have, of what you are meant to be. One thing that gets in the way of this habit of living in mystery — going back to silence and recollection — is what the author of *The Soul of the Apostolate* calls dissipation. We ought to have the custody of our hearts, to keep out those things that are going to distract us from God. Dissipations are rampant nowadays, because there are so many ways that we can satisfy a dopamine addiction. We can just go on social media, get caught up in TikTok, Instagram Reels, and YouTube Shorts, and see what is on our social media feed.

Have you ever wondered why it is called a feed? What kind of creatures consume a feed? Animals — barnyard animals. Here is your feed.

We are human. We are not animals. We do not have *feed*. We have *feasts*. We are not meant to be reduced to that level. Many of us living this life of dissipation have become like pigs. We are caught up in a feed. Instead of wonder, we doom scroll.

It is safe, however. It has its own sort of negative feedback: I can scroll until I am tired enough to fall asleep, in that nice negative feedback loop.

You are not called to that mediocrity. You are not called to be comfortable. As Pope Benedict has said, you are not made for comfort — you are made for greatness. It challenges us as engineering students, as any kind of student, as any kind of person living in this age.

Dissipation is the enemy of recollection. It prevents us from experiencing reality as mystery, gives us a false, counterfeit sense of control — and yet it controls us. We are enslaved. We are reduced. We have screens. Screens block out the mystery. Unlike screens, veils clothe mystery; they accentuate it; they

show what is behind the veil. We do not look at the veils, we look beyond them. Yet so often, we are stuck looking at screens. We are blocked. Dissipation is a great enemy of the interior life.

Watching for the Christ Already Within

The interior life begins with this knowledge: God is closer to us than we are to ourselves. Everything that drives us to obstruct, to screen out, and to dissipate does not need to be there, because we are already loved. God is actually our Father. He actually cares for us. He has sent Christ, his Son, so that all of us can be sons and daughters in Christ the Son — so we can be joined with him in his offering of himself to God the Father — so we can be ourselves teeming with life eternal, even here and now. This interior life happens in our interiority, in the recognition that God is already within us.

One of the attitudes we have to have as Christians always — it comes up every year in Advent — is an attitude of watching, of waiting for the coming of Christ. So we watch for him. St. John Henry Newman — himself an Oratorian priest, like myself — said that watching is that feeling you have when you are expecting a friend to come to your house, and for some reason he is delayed, but all of your thoughts are fixed on him, and you are just waiting for him to be there, desiring him to come. That is the attitude of watching.

Recall the friend already home, whom we met in the chapter on intimacy: we are waiting for our friend to show up, and then we come back to our house, and we find that he is already there. His car is parked in the driveway. We go inside, and he is already sitting on our couch.

What do you say to such a friend? Welcome. I see you made yourself at home.

Christ is already dwelling within us. Welcome him. Speak to him. Be silent with him. Gaze on his face with wonder. Look into his eyes. See how he gazes on you. He cares for you. Your sufferings are not far from his sufferings. For his mysteries are your mysteries. Your sufferings are his sufferings, and there is

no suffering, no wound, that you have undergone that he has not taken on himself. He has loved you so much. He is sorry when you feel like you cannot trust anyone. He is sorry when you feel like you have to aim for counterfeit things. But he just invites you. The interior life is a response to the invitation that Christ constantly gives us: "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest."

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Translations

The prayers from St. Augustine's *Confessions* use E. B. Pusey's public-domain translation. The closing line of Dante's *Paradiso* is Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's 1867 translation.

Icon

The cover art is Andrei Rublev's *The Trinity* (c. 1411 or 1425–1427), State Tretyakov Gallery, Moscow.